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Govt steps up bid to end impasse, protesters firm on Prachan's exit

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NEW DELHI: The government intensified efforts on Friday to break a stalemate with student protesters, pushing through cabinet a stringent bill cracking down on paper leaks, sacking top officers at the National Testing Agency and moving to hire specialists, but talks failed to make headway as the agitators refused to budge on their demand for Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

Two representatives of the Cockerhatch Janata Party (CJP) — which is heading the protests at Jantar Mantar — met Union Ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh at the Vithalbhai Patel House for about two hours, the second meeting of the two sides this week. The CJP submitted a written memorandum to the government, which said another meeting will be held on Saturday. The meeting will likely take place at 3.30 pm at the Constitution Club of India, CJP members said.

"The meeting went on for almost two hours. They had three main demands and five reform suggestions and we have them all. We have told them that we will meet them again tomorrow afternoon and tell them about the discussion we had among the government," Nadda said. CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka, who attended the talks

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(From left) Union ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh meet CJP members Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka at Vithalbhai Patel House in Delhi; and protesters gather at the Shivaji Park in Mumbai on Friday.



PTI, RAU SHINHO/HT PHOTO

Stricter anti-paper leak bill gets cabinet approval

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday approved a draft bill that will pave the way for harsher punishments — such as a jail term of up to 10 years and fine penalties of up to ₹10 crore — for those convicted of paper leaks, said people aware of the details.

The draft bill will amend The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, proposing a minimum punishment of five years' imprisonment for individuals involved in

paper leaks, the people cited above said.

The draft bill, which Modi mentioned in his video message last on Thursday night, will now be tabled in the Lok Sabha on Monday, said a person privy to the details.

The present law has provisions for three to five years' imprisonment for individuals, and five to 10 years' imprisonment and a minimum fine of ₹1 crore for those involved in the organised crime of cheating and paper leaks.

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OPPN LIKELY TO BLOCK PASSAGE OF EXAM BILL UNLESS PRADHAN RESIGNS

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NEW DELHI: The Centre's plan to enact stringent legislation against examination paper leaks faces an Opposition blockade in Parliament unless the government accepts its demand to dismiss education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, leaders of multiple parties told HT on Friday. Opposition parties have called a meeting on Monday to take a final decision on the proposed law.

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47 officials terminated as NTA 'rebuilds' agency

NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has terminated the services of 47 officials in what is being described as a "major overhaul" of the agency following a series of examination controversies, including the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, people familiar with the matter said on Friday.

The action comes amid continuing student protests demanding the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in NEET. Apart from the dismissals, legal and criminal pro-

ceedings are likely to be initiated against some officials based on findings of internal inquiries and inputs from probe agencies, the people said. The NTA is yet to disclose the names, ranks or specific reasons behind the terminations.

The overhauling of the agency is part of a wider restructuring of the examination body in line with the recommendations of the High-Level Committee of Experts. "These measures represent the first concrete step in the institutional rebuild of NTA..." the agency said.

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Trade breather: US keeps tariff on India at 10%

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NEW DELHI/WASHINGTON: India will pay a 10% tariff on most of its exports to the US from Friday after the Trump administration rolled out the levy under a new legal provision as the successor to the temporary duty of the same rate that expired on July 24.

The 10% rate is lower than the 12.5% India would have faced under the office of the US Trade Representative's (USTR) June draft, and averts a comparative disadvantage against China, Vietnam and around 36 other economies that were placed in the higher bracket. The tariff, imposed under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974, is paid on top of the applicable Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) duty, and follows the conclusion of one of two Section 301 investigations against India.

Alongside India, USTR placed 16 other economies in the 10% bracket — among them Pakistan, Sri Lanka and, notably, Bangladesh, a direct competitor in textiles and garments, one of India's largest export categories to the US. The lower rate applies to economies that have adopted a forced-labour import prohibition, committed to one through an Agreement on Reciprocal Trade, or implemented a partial regime with the same effect.

That said, the new duties under Section 301 are both temporary and partial, people aware of the matter said — temporary because the architecture is expected to be superseded once

10% RATE IS LOWER THAN THE 12.5% PROPOSED BY USTR IN JUNE, HELPING INDIA AVOID DISADVANTAGE AGAINST CHINA, VIETNAM AND 36 OTHER ECONOMIES

the interim BTA (bilateral trade agreement) is signed, and partial because only one of the two Section 301 investigations has concluded.

India's placement in the lower bracket followed a July 13 amendment to the Foreign Trade Policy banning the import of goods produced wholly or partly through forced or compulsory labour — a measure USTR had, in its June 2 draft report, found India to be without.

"Today's action will begin to correct what is both a human rights abuse and distortive trade practice to improve the welfare of workers everywhere," US Trade Representative Jamie Green said in a statement announcing the tariff. "I am encouraged by the trading partners who have moved quickly to adopt forced labour import prohibitions, and look forward to ensuring their effective enforcement."

The 60 economies covered by the action together account for over 99% of US imports. Alongside India, the White House named Argentina, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador,

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CABINET NOD TO ₹3K-CR CHEMICAL PARKS SCHEME

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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Friday approved the Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana Rasayan (BHAVYA Rasayan) scheme with a financial outlay of ₹3,000 crore to establish three dedicated chemical parks across the country. The scheme will be implemented over five years.

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FBI MAN HELD FOR MURDERING PREGNANT WIFE

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GURUGRAM: A 32-year-old man was arrested for allegedly strangling his pregnant wife to death at their home in Greenfield Colony in Faridabad earlier this week and staging the crime to resemble a fatal robbery, police said on Friday.

DELHI HC QUESTIONS EC OVER S.I.R. DUTY FOR GOVT TEACHERS

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi HC on Friday questioned the Election Commission over compelling government school teachers to serve in the Special Intensive Revision of rolls in Delhi, observing that such assignments should be voluntary rather than mandatory.

'Won't allow injustice to prevail': CJI assures youth

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Friday said that the Supreme Court's doors remain open to every citizen, assuring the nation's youth that the judiciary will protect their rights and address every legitimate grievance within the framework of law.

Speaking to HT, the CJI said, "I would want to assure every citizen and especially the youth... that if any injustice has been caused, the Supreme Court will hear the grievance within the bounds of law." Separately, the Supreme Court

SC SEEKS STATUS OF GOVT'S NEET MEASURES

The top court on Friday demanded clear answers from the Centre on whether it was keen to shift NEET-UG to a computer-based test, issues of data protection that may arise, and implementation of panel reports. It pointed out that steps such as deploying Air Force can only be an ad-hoc one and the effort should be to institutionalise the mechanism.

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agreed to hear on Monday two petitions on the alleged police excesses during the July 20 student march in Delhi.

From govt dept to police, Hauz Rani blaze report points to systemic lapses

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NEW DELHI: The magisterial inquiry into the deadly Hauz Rani fire that killed 23 people on June 3 has indicted multiple government agencies for a long list of failures on every level, which, it stated, allowed an illegally expanded building to continue operating as a bed and breakfast despite repeated warnings, official documents accessed by HT show.

The 111-page report, submitted to the office of the chief secretary of Delhi government this month, points to serious irregularities in the licensing, inspection and

monitoring of Flourish Stay B&B, and identifies lapses by at least four authorities — Delhi Police, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the Delhi tourism department and BSIS Rakdhan Power Ltd. It also blames the building's owner and management for carrying out unauthorised construction and operating without mandatory safety safeguards.

The inquiry is particularly critical of Delhi Police, the tourism department and MCD, and states that multiple opportunities to stop the illegal construction were missed due to officials who deliberately concealed facts and overlooked violations for years.



The 111-page report points to serious irregularities in the licensing, inspection and monitoring of Flourish Stay B&B. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

Boulders crush car in Himachal; 13 killed



The wreckage of a Tata Sumo after boulders fell on it in Himachal Pradesh's Lahaul-Spiti district on Friday, killing 13 people, including a six-month-old infant. Related story on page 6

PTI

Apex court bars unauthorised sharing of court hearing videos

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday restrained the extraction, editing, dissemination, reposting, uploading and monetisation of audio and video recordings of judicial proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission from the concerned court registries, observing that courts cannot become a "24/7 entertainment channel" and that access to virtual hearings requires regulation and a careful balancing of transparency with

SC SAID COURTS CAN'T BECOME '24/7 ENTERTAINMENT CHANNEL' AND ACCESS TO VIRTUAL HEARINGS NEEDS REGULATION

the administration of justice. Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Jyotsna Basu and V Mohana, passed the interim order while issuing notice on a public interest litigation seeking

safeguards against the misuse of livestreamed court proceedings through selective clipping, sensationalised circulation and commercial exploitation on digital platforms.

"As an interim measure, it is directed that there shall be no extraction, modification, monetisation, posting, reposting or uploading of audio-video recordings of judicial proceedings on any social media platform without the prior permission of the court registries," the bench said.

SC PROPOSES SPL COURTS FOR MANIPUR CASES

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday proposed the setting up of special courts to conduct day-to-day trials into the 2023 Manipur violence cases and directed the probe agencies to expeditiously complete investigation into all pending cases.

U.P. MAN GUNNED DOWN WIFE IN SUV SHE GIFTED HIM

MEERUT: Investigators probing the disappearance of a 23-year-old law student from Uttar Pradesh's Meerut district said on Friday that her husband has confessed to shooting her inside an SUV she gifted him and then dumping her body in Uttarakhnad.

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India slams China over illegal occupation in J&K

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NEW DELHI: India on Friday reacted strongly to China repeatedly raising sovereignty issues in official readouts of bilateral meetings, saying the Indian side hasn't violated China's sovereignty whereas Beijing continues to illegally occupy territories in the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir and has built projects in these regions.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaishwal

was responding to a Chinese readout of a meeting between external affairs minister S Jaishankar and his counterpart Wang Yi in Manila, which claimed the Indian minister had assured the Chinese side about respecting China's sovereignty, including issues such as Taiwan and Tibet. People familiar with the matter said Jaishankar made no such comments.

"Let me say that the external affairs minister said that when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be raising them," Jaishwal said.

15, INCLUDING 12 SOLDIERS, KILLED IN PAK SUICIDE BOMB ATTACK

DERA ISMAIL KHAN: Islamist militants rammed an explosive-laden vehicle into a Pakistani security checkpoint, killing 15 people, including 12 soldiers, in northwest Pakistan, the military said on Friday, adding that 12 militants had been killed in retaliation.

The attack took place overnight between Thursday and Friday in Tank district near the Afghan border. Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan claimed responsibility for the attack.

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Another Indian seafarer killed in Black Sea strike; LPG carrier comes under fire near Iran

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MUMBAI/NEW DELHI: An Indian seafarer was killed in a drone strike on a ship in the Black Sea last week, officials said on Friday, even as an LPG carrier Disha came under missile attack near Iran, leaving the vessel temporarily without manoeuvrability.

MY Omorfi was attacked while transiting the Black Sea, reportedly in Russian territorial

waters, on July 18, the external affairs ministry said in a statement. Chief Officer Sagar Gupta, one of three Indian nationals among the 10 crew members, was killed in the attack, while the two other Indian crew members are safe.

India on Friday condemned the attack on the Marshall Islands-flagged Omorfi and reiterated its call for upholding international obligations to ensure the safety and security of maritime navigation and the

BLACK SEA, YEMEN WATERS ADDED TO INDIA SHIPPING ALERT

The Directorate General of Maritime Administration has expanded its maritime security advisories beyond the Strait of Hormuz, warning Indian-flagged vessels and foreign ships carrying Indian seafarers to exercise extreme caution in the Black Sea and waters around Yemen following a surge in attacks. The advisories cover the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait, the Southern Red Sea and the Black Sea.

U.S. STRIKES IRAN AFTER TRUMP THREATS OVER RED SEA SHIPPING

US struck targets across Iran Friday after President Donald Trump vowed "military punishment" for Tehran and its Houthis allies for extending the war to a second major shipping checkpoint, the mouth of the Red Sea, Iran responded by firing at US bases in Arab countries and warning it may strike non-military buildings used by US personnel. Trump said that frozen Iranian assets will pay for damage to Hormuz shipping.



You, me and Cupid.exe

17 get life for 2014 Dalit man's murder in Yadgir

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BIDAR: A dispute over banners during a village festival in Yadgir district that turned into a caste-driven killing over a decade ago concluded on Thursday, with the sessions court convicting 20 people in the 2014 murder of Dalit leader Devendrapa Bhimappa Dalapati and sentencing 17 of them to life imprisonment.

The court found that the prosecution had established the case through eyewitness testimony, medical evidence and material objects recovered during the investigation. One accused was sentenced to seven years imprisonment, while two others received six months in prison.

The court also imposed a collective fine of ₹4.25 lakh, directing that it be paid to the victims' legal heirs, and advised the family to seek additional compensation through the District Legal Services Authority.

According to investigators, the violence began during the annual Sri Chowdeswari Devi Jatra Mahotsava in Kanyakulur village on January 15, 2014, when banners displaying photographs of Scheduled Caste and upper caste communities were torn.

"The incident dates back to January 15, 2014. As in previous years, the annual Sri Chowdeswari Devi Jatra Mahotsava was being held at Kanyakulur village under Shahapur Police Station limits," Yadgir Superintendent of Police Pruthivi Shankar said.

"During the festival, tensions flared between members of the Scheduled Caste community

ONE ACCUSED WAS SENTENCED TO SEVEN YEARS' IMPRISONMENT, WHILE TWO OTHERS RECEIVED SIX MONTHS. THE COURT ALSO IMPOSED A FINE OF ₹4.25 LAKH

and members of the upper caste community. The reason: tearing of court orders and banners that carried photographs of their respective community leaders."

The disagreement continued into the next day before erupting into violence on January 17. "What started as a dispute over symbols and banners wound, within 48 hours, turn into a brutal murder," the Superintendent of Police said.

Police said villagers had gathered near the Anjaneya Temple to resolve the dispute while a group of accused had also assembled nearby. The confrontation later shifted near the old Ram Pancharaj building, where Devendrapa had gone to meet with other villagers for talks.

Principal public prosecutor Gurulingappa Shrinani said the discussions quickly descended into violence after the accused allegedly abused Devendrapa using caste slurs. "The accused allegedly hurled caste-based abuses at Devendrapa, accusing him of interfering in every matter," Tel said.

According to the prosecution, Devendrapa ran towards

the Jumma Mosque in an attempt to escape. "The accused chased him, armed with axes, clubs and stones. With the intention to murder him, they knocked him down and attacked him repeatedly," Tel said.

Court records showed that he suffered multiple injuries to his head, abdomen, shoulders, knees, back and feet. His left arm was twisted and, according to the prosecution, he was dragged by his legs after the assault.

The prosecution also told the court that when he asked for water, he was abused again. A person who tried to rescue him was struck with a club and injured. Devendrapa died at the scene.

Following the attack, Shahapur police registered a case and later filed a chargesheet against 32 accused under provisions relating to unlawful assembly, riot, murder, attempt to murder, intentional insult and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

During the trial, the prosecution cited 68 witnesses, of whom 37 testified before the court. The defence argued that several leaders had been falsely implicated because of village rivalry, but the court rejected those submissions.

The court has accepted all arguments put forth by the prosecution. Thirty seven witnesses were examined and the medical evidence supported our case of murder with common intention. The fine amount will now go to the victim's family and we have also suggested they apply for DLSA compensation," Tel said.

12% Councillors during R: CEO; says no provision for aid to kin

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BENGALURU: Twelve Booth Level Officers (BLOs) deployed for Karnataka's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls have died since the exercise began on June 30, chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anbukumar said on Friday.

The deaths have drawn demands for compensation, a review of working conditions and greater safeguards for thousands of teachers and government employees assigned to the state's electoral verification exercise.

The Chief Electoral Officer confirmed that Booth Level Officers had died during the exercise. He said the Election Commission's guidelines do not provide the compensation to the families of officials who die while on duty.

"There are reports that some BLOs and officers have passed away, but I do not have information about the reasons," Anbukumar said.

He added, "There is no provision for compensation to the families of BLOs who die while on duty."

Among those who died was Bhuvana, a Village Administrative Officer supervising Booth Level Officers, who was killed

on Saturday after a truck struck her scooter on Kunjal Road near Gurlu in Tumakuru district while she was travelling for election related work. A resident of Varadanyakanahalli village in Bengaluru Rural District's Nelmangala taluk, she suffered severe head injuries and later died at Siddaganga Hospital.

Her uncle, Ramesh, said she had attended a Special Intensive Revision review meeting at the Deputy Commissioner's office the previous evening before returning home around 10 pm. She left again at about 6:30 am the following morning to resume field work when the collision occurred.

"She was under pressure. She said she would quit her job. In fact, we were planning to arrange her marriage. There are no fixed working hours. They were made to work without considering their personal life. There were too many responsibilities on a single person," Ramesh said.

The Karnataka State Village Administrative Officers Association linked her death to what it described as the demanding schedule associated with the electoral revision exercise.

General Secretary Shivnand Nayak said Bhuvana had been travelling from Bengaluru to Tumakuru early in the morning

THE DEATHS HAVE DRAWN DEMANDS FOR EX-GRATIA, WORKING CONDITIONS REVIEW AND GREATER SAFEGUARDS FOR THOUSANDS OF TEACHERS AND EMPLOYEES

to carry out revision work. "We have been protesting here since yesterday. VAO Bhuvana, who was working in Tumakuru district, was coming from Bengaluru at 6 am for SIR work under pressure from the DC, Tehsiladar and AC. While travelling on her two wheeler at such an early hour to get to work, she was hit by an unknown vehicle. She passed away in the hospital," Nayak said.

Another death was reported from Bidar district, where Sunil, a 45-year old government school teacher deployed on District Congress Committee in Bhalgi, suffered a heart attack.

According to people familiar with the matter, he collapsed while at work on Thursday and was taken to the Bidar Institute of Medical Sciences, where doctors informed his family

that he had suffered a heart attack. He died the following day.

The latest fatality involved a teacher from Kurubarahalli Government School in Bengaluru, who also suffered a heart attack while engaged in the revision exercise.

Booth Level Officers are drawn largely from government school teachers and other public servants, who have been tasked with visiting every household to verify voter details, collecting supporting documents and updating electoral rolls within a fixed deadline.

The deaths have triggered political reactions across party lines.

Congress leader F Jakkappa questioned the need for the Special Intensive Revision and referred to Bhuvana's death while seeking relief for her family.

"RSS, BJP imposed SIR in Karnataka. It was not required at all. Bhuvana, a development officer, met with an accident while going on duty, and she died. The request for the BLOs is a duty imposed by the Central Government Election Commission of India. We are with the family of Bhuvana, and the government should provide compensation to the family," Jakkappa said.

Karnataka BJP President B. Y. Vijayendra also sought compensation for the families of the deceased officials, saying the deaths reflected the pressure under which Booth Level Officers had been working.

He urged both the Election Commission and the state government to review the conditions under which election personnel were deployed.

Government employees' and teachers' associations have demanded ex-gratia payments, an independent inquiry into the deaths and a reassessment of the workload assigned to Booth Level Officers.

They argue that long working hours, extensive field visits and strict timelines have placed excessive pressure on teachers and other government employees drafted for election work.

Civil society organisation My Vote My Right has called for regulated working hours, improved training and withdrawal of disciplinary notices issued to Booth Level Officers and compensation of ₹30 lakh for the families of those who died during the exercise.

Meanwhile, the Booth Level Officers in Karnataka said they are receiving notices threatening them with disciplinary action if their progress does not increase from 60% to 75% "in a day".

PRIYANK QUIZZES PM'S DELAYED RESPONSE TO NEET PAPER LEAK ISSUE

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BENGALURU: Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge on Friday questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi's delayed response to the alleged NEET question paper leak issue, saying the students' demand was for the removal of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and not mere assurances.

Reacting to the Prime Minister's video message to students ahead of the Union Cabinet meeting, Kharge said the Centre had failed to announce any concrete action and accused it of ignoring the demand for accountability.

"It was so important, what took him so long to respond to it? I would have been extremely grateful to the PM if he came out and said in the video that I am throwing Dharmendra Pradhan out of my cabinet, but that never happened. The demand is simple: Dharmendra Pradhan should go," Kharge, who is Congress president Mahatma Kharge's son, told reporters.

Questioning why the Union Education Minister continued to support Kharge said, "Why is Dharmendra Pradhan so indispensable? What secrets does he carry of Modi or of Shah? They have enough time to mock the Congress, but when it comes to the students' future, what concrete thing has he said?"

On police action against protesting students, Kharge accused the Centre of suppressing dissent and said students were protesting for reforms.

Cong, BJP stage stir, counter-stirs on NEET

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BENGALURU: Protests and counter-protests erupted over the alleged NEET question paper leak and the political fallout from the issue were held across several parts of Karnataka on Friday, with police detaining protesters, preventing rival groups from clashing and stepping up security at multiple locations.

Student groups, Dalit organisations, Youth Congress activists and civil society groups held protests over the alleged NEET irregularities and the reported police action against students in Delhi. The BJP has been protesting against the attack on its leaders during their agitation near the Congress office in Bengaluru on Wednesday.

Congress workers reportedly threw eggs at BJP legislator B P Harish, when he took part in the agitation to protest the Congress demonstration in front of the BJP office at Mallawaram in the city. In Vijayapura, the BJP, led by district president Gurulingappa Angadi, held a protest at Ambekar Circle, accusing the Congress government of "hoofism" and later marched towards the Deputy Commissioner's office.

Simultaneously, Progressive Dalit organisations and Aam Aadmi Party activists opposed the BJP protest, raising slogans against the party. Police intervened to prevent a confrontation between the two groups, detained more than 15 Dalit activists and brought the tense situation under control.

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BENGALURU: AICC General Secretary K C Venugopal on Friday said the expansion of chief minister D K Shivakumar-led cabinet in Karnataka is on the cards and it will happen any time.

Shivakumar, former CM Siddaramaiah and Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPC) president B K Hariprasad were in New Delhi on Tuesday to discuss the expansion.

However, the discussion could not take place because the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge and several party leaders and MPs participated in a dharna outside Prime Minister Narendra Modi's residence over the police action against students protesting the NEET paper leak. Cabinet expansion in Karnataka is on the cards; it will happen any time," Venugopal told reporters in response to a question. Ministerial aspirants are lobbying



K C Venugopal

intensely for induction into the cabinet.

Shivakumar, Siddaramaiah and Hariprasad visited Delhi last week too, and held the first round of discussions with the party's top leadership, including Rahul Gandhi, Venugopal, and Randeep Singh Surjewala, the General Secretary in charge of Karnataka.

As Kharge was not part of this meeting, Shivakumar had subsequently met him in Bengaluru and held discussions. Shivakumar was sworn in as chief minister along with 13 Ministers on June 3, following Siddaramaiah's resignation as CM on May 28. With the sanctioned

strength of Karnataka's ministry being 34, including the CM, 20 berths are still vacant and pressure is mounting on Shivakumar to expand his cabinet. He also said that the party has begun the process of selecting Karnataka BJP Congress Committee (DCC) presidents following an initial meeting with the state leadership.

Venugopal told reporters that the Congress leadership in the state held an initial meeting and further decisions will be taken "in due course." "We are going to begin the DCC presidents' selection process in Karnataka. This was an initial meeting with the Karnataka leadership, and further decisions will be taken in due course," he said.

When asked about the second list of DCC presidents, Venugopal said, "Don't worry, we will announce it soon. It will be made public." After DK Shivakumar took over the office of the Chief Minister in June, the Congress is under a process of leadership overhaul.

Veterinary doctors allege recruitment irregularities in state

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BENGALURU: A group of veterinary doctors has lodged a complaint with the Vidhana Soudha police, alleging large-scale irregularities in the KPSRC recruitment process for 400 veterinary officer posts in the animal husbandry and fisheries department, and sought a probe into the selection process.

The recruitment examination was conducted by the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSRC) in January 2026, while the final selection list was published on July 17.

The complainants alleged that several candidates were approached by middlemen who demanded between ₹70 lakh and ₹80 lakh in exchange for securing appointments.

They claimed that they had audio clips of conversations, which they have submitted to

the police.

They further charged that some tests took place in resorts. The complainants also questioned the fairness of the recruitment process. In their complaint, they further alleged that several candidates who secured high scores were relatives of persons holding influential positions in the KPSRC.

Some complainants alleged that many successful candidates had failed in their degree examinations. The complaint comes after Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot, on July 13, suspended KPSRC Chairman Shivashankar SShahkar over allegations that he facilitated the illegal selection of his two daughters as industrial extension officers. The BJP alleged that the KPSRC has become a hub of corruption under the Congress government.

Coffee estate owner held after child shot during daily wage dispute, probe on: Police

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BENGALURU: A dispute over daily wages at a coffee plantation in Chikmagalur district left a child with a gunshot wound to the head on Friday, leading to the arrest of the estate owner and an investigation into the firearm used during the confrontation, police said.

Police said the incident occurred around 10 am at Balehalli village in Mudigere taluk after six migrant workers from

'THE INCIDENT TOOK PLACE AFTER SIX MIGRANT WORKERS FROM ASSAM DEMANDED AN INCREASE IN DAILY WAGES

Assam demanded an increase in their daily wages. The workers sought ₹8-400 a day while estate owner Jagadish Gowda, 62, allegedly offered ₹350 immedi-

ately and said the remaining ₹50 would be paid later. The workers rejected the proposal and decided to leave the estate to seek work elsewhere.

An argument broke out between the workers and the estate owner when they prepared to leave. Police said the confrontation intensified, with allegations that some workers attempted to assault Gowda.

Mudigere Circle Inspector B Rajashankar said he fired a place while the estate owner was allegedly trying to intimidate the

workers. "The incident occurred at around 10 in the morning on Friday when Assam workers demanded higher daily wages. The owner, Jagadish Gowda, refused to meet their demand, following which the workers decided to leave and work at another estate," he said.

During the confrontation, a pellet or bullet struck a child in the head, leaving the minor critically injured.

Police registered a case under the Arms Act and taken Jagadish Gowda into custody.

Developer to rebuild 49 apartments for free after structural defect found

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BENGALURU: Real estate developer SNN Raj Corp on Friday announced the complete reconstruction of 49 apartment blocks at its upcoming project, SNN Raj Etterna in HSR Layout, at zero cost to the buyers, and the entire country have officials, one of the residential towers of the multi-storey complex built by SNN Raj Corp tilted slightly.

He said the gravity of the situation, the builder voluntarily approached the BBMP Chief

Commissioner M Maheshwar Rao with a proposal to demolish the structure.

The realty firm's director (operations) Anuj Sanjay Jain, said there was a mistake in the soil testing which caused the loss. "We have decided to rebuild the entire structure. We will demolish it, which will take at least six months. Another 18 months will be needed to rebuild the structure," Jain said.

He said this information has been returned to the home buyers who were initially disappointed but later agreed.

A statement issued by the firm said, "Despite the structures having received the Occupancy Certificate and already ready for handover, the developer has decided to prioritise long-term structural integrity and customer safety over financial considerations."

The company said the borehole readings were interchanged and it was discovered this only after the structure was ready.

The total number of units in the project is 572, out of which 822 have already been handed over for possession.

State's guarantee schemes now national template: CM

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BENGALURU: Chief minister D K Shivakumar on Friday said that Karnataka's five guarantee schemes had evolved into a national template for welfare politics, claiming that several states, including those governed by the BJP, had adopted similar programmes after initially opposing the Congress government's initiatives.

Speaking at an event, Shivakumar said the guarantees introduced after the Congress came to power in Karnataka had reshaped electoral politics beyond the state. "Our five guarantees have become the guarantees of this country, not just Karnataka. If anyone, not just Karnataka, they decided to follow the Karnataka model," he said.

that the Centre and senior BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, had questioned the guarantee schemes before similar welfare measures began appearing in other states. He said governments in Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, West Bengal and Bihar had successfully introduced comparable programmes.

Projecting Karnataka as one of the country's principal economic engines, Shivakumar said the state's development model extended beyond welfare programmes and rested on its leadership in education, technology, manufacturing and innovation. "The entire world is looking at India, and world leaders now come to Bengaluru first. Earlier, they used to go to Delhi, but the situation has changed because Bengaluru is a talent hub with immense human resources," he



DK Shivakumar

said. Shivakumar argued that Karnataka's skilled workforce had become one of its greatest strengths, saying the state was producing professionals who contributed not only to India's economy but also to global industries.

Expanding on Karnataka's development strategy, Shivakumar said Bengaluru should not view neighbouring southern cities as competitors. "We are not competing with Chennai, Telangana, Hyderabad or Visakhapatnam. The cities of South India will work as one team. These cities contribute 30% to the country's progress," he said.

Instead, he said Karnataka measured itself against Delhi and Mumbai, pointing to the state's educational ecosystem as a competitive advantage. "We have 250 engineering colleges. Every year, 13,940 doctors, one lakh engineers and one lakh healthcare professionals are produced in Karnataka. No other city in the country can match us in this regard," he said.

He also claimed Bengaluru had 2.6 million engineers, compared with 1.5 million in Hyderabad, describing the state's human capital as the foundation of its economic success. Tracing state's growth, Shivakumar cited institutions such as the Indian Institute of Space Technology and Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, saying the state's development had been driven by sustained investment in science, education and technology. "Talent in this country begins from Karnataka," he said.

The chief minister said the state would establish the country's first Artificial Intelligence University, maintaining that the state's knowledge ecosystem continued to attract global investment. "Twenty five years ago, they asked for international schools. Today, out of 140 international schools in the country, 38 are in Bengaluru and Karnataka. Around two lakh foreign passport holders are working in Bengaluru. That is our strength," he said.

DKS TAKES DIG AT PM'S COMMENT ON PAPER LEAKS

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar took a subtle dig at Prime Minister Narendra Modi after the PM's late night video message highlighting the government's fast-track court for paper leak cases.

"I am very happy. At least he has opened up after 15 days, or one month," he has opened up. I think that is very important because we all work for our children and all work for the future. At least now, I think he has opened up, and the entire country has opened up. Thanks for that," he said. Earlier this week the protest against NEET irregularities continued in Mandya, with activists burning an effigy of minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Cong to hold party strengthening event

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: AICC General Secretary K C Venugopal on Friday said that the Congress will hold a party organisation strengthening programme, "Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan", with the appointment of new district unit chiefs across Karnataka, and asserted that the party will return to power in the 2028 Assembly poll.

Venugopal attended the meeting regarding the "Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan" at the party office here with Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, former CM Siddaramaiah, state Congress President B K Hariprasad, AICC General Secretary in-charge of Karnataka Randeep Singh Surjewala among others.

"It was a fruitful meeting. Thankful to the PCC chief, CM after in-charge. We have said that the selection of DCC presidents in Karnataka should be completed before August 24. Observers will be neutral. They will find the most capable person in that district to become a president. They will choose 6 names but on a preference basis," Venugopal told reporters after the meeting. "It was a fruitful meeting. Thankful to the PCC chief, CM after in-charge. We have said that the selection of DCC presidents in Karnataka should be completed before August 24. Observers will be neutral. They will find the most capable person in that district to become a president. They will choose 6 names but on a preference basis," he said.

Fresh bid to end Cauvery deadlock as CMs plan talk

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI/BENGALURU: A proposed meeting between Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar and his Tamil Nadu counterpart C Joseph Vijay has opened a fresh political channel to address the long-running Cauvery dispute, with both governments indicating a willingness to discuss water sharing and Karnataka's proposed method of balancing reservoir amid worsening drought conditions across the basin.

Tamil Nadu minister for agriculture and farmers' welfare R Vinodh said on Friday that Vijay would travel to Karnataka in the first week of August to raise the Mekedatu issue, reiterating the state's opposition to the project. "The chief minister is set to visit Karnataka next month. Right from the beginning, we have been saying that the Government of Tamil Nadu will not permit Karnataka to construct the dam. The chief minister is going regarding this matter in the first week of August," Vinodh said.

He said Vijay would also seek Tamil Nadu's share of Cauvery water. A Karnataka official informed the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) that it could not release additional water for June and July because of deficient rainfall.

"The chief minister will demand Tamil Nadu's share of water for the sake of establishing our rights," Vinodh said.

Responding to reports of the meeting, Shivakumar said Karnataka was willing to resolve inter-state issues through dialogue and was prepared to engage with Tamil



C Joseph Vijay and DK Shivakumar

Nadu. Speaking after attending the CEOs' Breakfast Meeting ahead of the Bengaluru Tech Summit, he declined to disclose details of a letter sent by the Tamil Nadu chief minister, saying the state government had been occupied with Cabinet expansion and other official work.

"I don't want to disclose now. I'm very busy next week with my Cabinet expansion and all those things. We are ready to speak with everyone, share things with everyone and work with everyone," Shivakumar said.

According to officials familiar with the matter, Tamil Nadu sought the meeting and Shivakumar subsequently invited Vijay for talks in Bengaluru, with August 3 being considered as a tentative date. There is no confirmation yet on whether Vijay has accepted the invitation.

The discussions are expected to focus on Cauvery water releases and Karnataka's proposal to release the Mekedatu balancing reservoir in Shivakumar's Kanakapura Assembly constituency. Tamil Nadu has opposed the project for nearly 15 years, arguing that it would adversely affect farmers, particularly in the Cauvery delta.



C Joseph Vijay

Earlier this week, Vijay chaired a consultation with legal experts who have represented the Tamil Nadu government in the Mekedatu litigation over the past 15 years. State minister for natural resources and law R Nirmal Kumar said the government would decide its next course of action after examining the recommendations made during the meeting.

Political parties in Tamil Nadu have also sharpened their stand ahead of the proposed talks.

BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathi said, "Vijay during the meeting should very categorically and clearly state that the Mekedatu dam project, which was built without Tamil Nadu's consent, I think since Congress is also in the government in Tamil Nadu, he has to say it very, very clearly that they cannot play games."

On July 23, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami urged the Tamil Nadu government to press Karnataka to release the state's allocated share of Cauvery water for June and July.

He said Karnataka had released 2.91 tmcft against the 9.19 tmcft mandated under the Supreme Court's verdict.

The Tamil Nadu Assembly

unanimously adopted a resolution on July 19 opposing Karnataka's plan to construct the Mekedatu reservoir. Vijay led the resolution, with opposition parties, including the AIADMK and Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin, extending support. The Tamil Nadu Congress also backed the government's stand despite the Congress being in power in Karnataka.

The proposed meeting comes days after Karnataka told the CWMA that it could not release additional Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu under the Supreme Court-mandated monthly schedule because of deficient rainfall and drought-like conditions.

Karnataka informed the Authority that storage in its four Cauvery basin reservoirs stood at 48.97 tmcft against the 30-year average of 51.82 tmcft. Tamil Nadu, meanwhile, said it had received 3.442 tmcft between June 1 and July 19 against its scheduled allocation of 28.37 tmcft, leaving 24.896 tmcft yet to be released.

Karnataka told the Authority that below-normal rainfall over the past five weeks in Kodagu, Hassan, Mysuru, Bengaluru Urban, Bengaluru Rural, Ramnagara and neighbouring districts had sharply reduced inflows into reservoirs.

The Authority said the Cauvery basin was entering a distress year and advised basin states to prioritise drinking water over irrigation while continuing to follow the water sharing framework laid down under the Cauvery award for years of deficient inflows.

(With inputs from Arun Dev in Bengaluru)

MADRAS HC ORDERS S.IT PROBE INTO PREGNANT WOMAN'S DEATH

Ayesha Arvind

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BENGALURU: The Madras high court on Friday directed the Tamil Nadu government to constitute a special investigation team (SIT) to investigate the death of a 24-year-old pregnant woman from Sivaganga district directed authorities to conduct a fresh post-mortem examination through a neutral medical board.

Jusali Victoria Govt of the Madras bench of the Madras high court directed the director general of police (DGP) to constitute the SIT within 48 hours with officers not below the rank of superintendent of police from the CB-CID or other specialised units. The judge also directed the police to hand over the entire case records and digital evidence to the SIT.

The high court also directed the director of medical education to constitute a "Neutral Medical Board" within 24 hours, adding that "doctors who conducted the earlier postmortem cannot serve on the Board."

"Pending its constitution, the body has been directed to be preserved at the Government Medical College Hospital, Pudukkottai. The Medical Board has been directed to conduct a post-mortem within 48 hours of its constitution," Justice Govt said. The Court passed the order on a writ petition and a miscellaneous petition filed by S Fatima Beevi, mother of the deceased, Afrin, seeking transfer of the investigation to an independent SIT and a fresh autopsy to ascertain the actual cause of her daughter's death.

According to the petitioner, Afrin married one Mohammed Asan on January 25, 2026, and was about four months pregnant when she died. Fatima Beevi alleged that her daughter faced dowry harassment.

ASSAULT OF YOUTH CONGRESS WORKERS IN 2023

ADGP suspended for 'interference' in probe

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala government on Friday issued an order suspending ADGP M R Ajithkumar pending disciplinary proceedings over allegations that he interfered with the investigation into the alleged assault on Youth Congress workers during the Nava Kerala Sadas programme in Alappuzha in 2023.

The suspension order, issued by Chief Secretary Kishanwarthi Sinha under Rule 30 of the All India Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1969, was based on the findings of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe into the assault on Youth Congress workers registered at the Alappuzha South Police Station.

The case relates to the alleged assault on Youth Congress workers, including current Alappuzha MLA AD Thomas, by members of the Chief Minister's security and escort team during the Nava Kerala Sadas programme on December 15, 2023.

According to the order, progress reports submitted by the SIT headed by Crime Branch SP Shoukath, revealed that earlier investigating officers were subjected to severe pressure from the office of the then ADGP (Law and Order).

"The office of the then ADGP (Law and Order), M R Ajithkumar IPS, had influenced the course of investigation and shaped it in a way that the case finally ended in a Refer Report, and the earlier Investigating Officers alleged that they were pressured to submit the case towards the Refer Report," the suspension order said.

The order referred to statements recorded by the SIT from former investigating officers, including Inspector K P Tomson, DySP Asan K S and DySP Sunilraj.

According to the order, Inspector Tomson told the SIT that Ajithkumar personally examined the case diary during a meeting, expressed dissatisfaction with the investigation and questioned findings indicating the involvement of the Chief Minister's



M R Ajithkumar

security and escort team. The order said DySP Sunilraj specifically referred to communications conveyed through the Superintendent of Police stating that "the CM PSO case may be referred by tomorrow" and "I think investigation is over and only pending for refer notice," indicating attempts to influence the outcome of the investigation.

The SIT also found that Grade SI Gireesh and SI Sreekanth, both attached to Ajithkumar's office, played active roles in ensuring that the case ended in a Refer Report to protect the accused, the order said.

Following a memorandum issued by the Director General of Police-cum-State Police Chief, Ajithkumar submitted an interim explanation on July 21 denying all allegations.

He contended that the SIT had exceeded its mandate and sought an opportunity to cross-verify the statements of officers and access earlier departmental reports.

However, the State Police Chief found the explanation unsatisfactory and recommended disciplinary action.

Reinstating Ajithkumar's defence, the government observed that while Section 36 of the Code of Criminal Procedure empowers a supervisory officer to intervene in such intervention must be lawful and aimed at ensuring justice.

"Under Section 36 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, a supervisory officer may intervene in an investigation by exercising the powers of the Station House Officer. Such intervention should be lawful and aimed at ensuring justice. Here, the intervention by Ajithkumar IPS was not in accordance with law and, more

importantly, it led to injustice to the victims and protection for the accused from legal action," the order said.

Citing the need to maintain public confidence in the investigation and to prevent any possible interference with further proceedings, the government placed Ajithkumar, who is currently serving as Chairman and Managing Director of the Kerala State Beverages Corporation Ltd., under immediate suspension pending disciplinary proceedings.

Following reports of Ajithkumar's suspension, MLA Thomas and Youth Congress workers welcomed the decision. This is not the first time Ajithkumar has been courted controversy.

Allegations were raised against him over the handling of an incident related to the disruption of Thrissur Purnam in 2024. Meanwhile, Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said that the DGP government's policy was to take strict action against any public servant found guilty of abusing power or indulging in illegal activities.

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BALLARI-GUNTAKAL

Cabinet clears ₹1k-cr rail line expansion

Neha LM Tripathi

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NEW DELHI: The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Friday approved the construction of the third and fourth railway lines on the Ballari-Guntakal section spanning Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh at an estimated cost of ₹1,000 crore.

The project, covering three districts across the two states, will add about 46 km to the Indian Railways network, the government said.

The proposed multi-tracking project will enhance connectivity to approximately 99 villages, which are having a population of above 10,000. The capacity enhancement will improve rail connectivity to several prominent tourist destinations across the country, including Ballari Fort, Sri Kumara Swamy Temple, the government said in a statement.

The Centre said the route is a key corridor for transporting iron ore, dolomite, limestone, iron and steel, coal, fertilisers and foodgrains.

"The capacity augmentation works will result in additional freight traffic of magnitude 16.22 MTPA (Million Tonnes Per Annum)," the statement said.

THE ROUTE IS A KEY FREIGHT CORRIDOR FOR TRANSPORTING IRON ORE, DOLOMITE, LIMESTONE, COAL AND FOODGRAINS

According to the government, the project has been planned under the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan to improve multimodal connectivity and logistics efficiency through integrated planning and stakeholder consultations. It said the project would provide seamless connectivity for the movement of people, goods and services.

"The Railways being an environment friendly and energy efficient mode of transportation, will help both in achieving climate goals and minimizing logistics cost of the country, reduce oil import (1.32 Crore Litres) and lower CO2 emissions (6.67 Crore kg), which is equivalent to plantation of 0.27 crore trees," the statement said.

The government added that the increased line capacity would improve mobility, operational efficiency and service reliability for Indian Railways.

T'gana schools, colleges shut amid bandh over NEET protest

Srinivasa Rao Apparao

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HYDERABAD: Educational Institutions across Telangana remained closed on Friday as a statewide bandh called by student organisations disrupted academic activities in protest against the alleged NEET-UG question paper leak, repeated irregularities in national-level entrance examinations and the Centre's handling of the education system.

The protesters also condemned the alleged police lathi charge on students demonstrating in New Delhi over the examination controversy.

The bandh, backed by a broad coalition of student and youth organisations, led to the closure of schools, junior colleges, degree colleges and universities across the state. Several universities also postponed examinations scheduled for the day.

The shutdown was called by the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), All India Students' Federation (AISF), All India Students' Union (AISU), All India Forum for Democratic Students (AIFDS), All India Students Body (AISB), All India Progressive Students Union (AIPSU), All India Students' Association (AISA), Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), All India Youth



Members of the Students Islamic Organisation (SIO) stage a solidarity gathering at Charminar in Hyderabad on Friday.

Federation (AIYF) and Students Islamic Organisation (SIO).

"We demand the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, as he is morally responsible for the NEET paper leak and successive failures in conducting public examinations," AISF state secretary Putta Lakshman said. He also sought stringent punishment for those involved in the alleged paper leak, withdrawal of cases registered against protesting students, and measures to restore transparency and credibility in the country's examination system.

NSUI state president Yadavala Venkataswamy said the bandh was total and peaceful. "We want exemplary punishment for those responsible for the alleged NEET paper leak, and Rs 1 crore ex gratia for the families of students who allegedly

died by suicide following the examination controversy," he said.

The bandh had a widespread impact across Hyderabad and other districts. Several government and private schools declared a holiday in anticipation of the protests.

The agitation also drew political support, with the Bharat Bashira Samithi (BBS) and the Congress holding separate protests. BBS working president K T Rama Rao participated in a demonstration organised by the party in the city. He was accompanied by Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, as he is morally responsible for the NEET paper leak and successive failures in conducting public examinations," AISF state secretary Putta Lakshman said. He also sought stringent punishment for those involved in the alleged paper leak, withdrawal of cases registered against protesting students, and measures to restore transparency and credibility in the country's examination system.

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SIKKIM COLLAPSE: BODY OF KERALA GEOLOGIST TO REACH TODAY: CM

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Chief Minister P V Sathidev on Friday said the body of a Kerala-based geologist who died in the NPHC hydropower project tunnel collapse in Sikkim on July 20 will reach the southern state on July 26.

Twenty-five people died in the incident, including Anesh Mohan, who hails from Pampady in Kottayam district of Kerala. The Chief Minister's office (CMO), in a statement, said that Mohan's body, which was recovered late Thursday night, will reach Kochi airport at 7 am. It said that the body, which was recovered late Thursday night, reached Kolkata airport by around noon on Friday as it was transported by road from Sikkim.

AMMK seeks action against one MLA for defying party whip

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK) leaders on Friday petitioned Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J C D Prabhakar, seeking the disqualification of a party member, S Kamaraj, for allegedly defying the party whip during the Assembly floor test in May.

AMMK treasurer M Karikalan, accompanied by party functionaries, submitted the petition at the Secretariat on behalf of party general secretary T V Dhinarajan.

"On behalf of our general secretary T V Dhinarajan, we met the Speaker of the legislative assembly and handed over a complaint. As you all know, during the floor test, Mannargudi MLA S Kamaraj acted contrary to the instructions given by our leader (Dhinarajan). Based on that, we have submitted a petition to the Speaker requesting him to take action against Kama-



JCD Prabhakar

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KERALA MAN SENTENCED TO SIX YRS FOR SEXUAL ASSAULT OF MINOR

Press Trust of India

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IDUKKI: A Kerala court on Friday convicted and sentenced to six years of rigorous imprisonment a man accused of sexually assaulting a minor girl at his residence near Vagamon last year.

The accused, Eashwar (46), was sentenced to varying jail terms for a total of six years under the provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act by Idukki Fast Track Court (POCSO) Judge Nibel DS, special public prosecutor (SPP) Shijomon Joseph said.

The court also imposed a fine of ₹30,000 on the convict, the SPP said.

As the varying jail terms have to be served concurrently and the highest of the punishments is four years, he will have to serve only that, the prosecutor said.

According to the prosecution, the man was arrested last year when the accused reached the 15-year-old girl's home and asked for a glass of water.

When she gave him the water, he grabbed her, the SPP said.

He let her go after she raised an alarm, the prosecutor said. The SPP said that the court examined 13 witnesses and perused 14 documents before arriving at its decision holding the accused guilty of the offence.

The court also directed that if the fine amount is paid by the convict, it should be given to the girl.

It also recommended to the District Legal Services Authority to provide adequate compensation to the child.

THE ACCUSED WAS SENTENCED TO VARYING JAIL TERMS FOR A TOTAL OF SIX YEARS UNDER THE PROVISIONS OF POCSO ACT

T'gana plans global expansion of SCCL

Srinivasa Rao Apparao

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana government said on Friday it plans to protect, strengthen and transform state-owned Singareni Collieries Company Ltd (SCCL) into a globally competitive enterprise that can transport critical mineral blocks in India and abroad, deputy chief minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka said.

Chairing a meeting with senior officials of SCCL and Telangana Power Generation Corporation (TGENCO) at Singareni headquarters in Kohangudi, Vikramarka said the coal miner should participate in auctions for critical mineral blocks in countries such as Australia and South Africa.

"Singareni should also diversify into the mining of critical minerals such as lithium and cobalt, which are essential for semiconductor manufacturing, microchips, electric vehicle bat-



Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka

teries and other advanced technologies," said Vikramarka, who also holds the energy portfolio.

He said the energy sector is expected to undergo a major transformation over the next 15 to 20 years, with rapid growth in solar power, pumped storage, wind energy, hydrogen, rare earth minerals and battery energy storage systems gradually reducing dependence on coal-based thermal power.

"In view of these changes, Singareni should not remain

confined to coal mining alone but should proactively diversify into emerging sectors," he said.

Highlighting SCCL's strengths, Vikramarka said the company has decades of mining expertise and a large pool of skilled engineers and professionals that should be leveraged to execute mining projects of international standards.

Describing Singareni as the "soul of Telangana," he said the 130-year-old institution has played a key role in the state's development and assured it of the government's continued support.

He noted that while SCCL once enjoyed a monopoly in coal production, the Union government's policy of auctioning coal blocks had increased private participation, forcing public sector companies to compete in a more challenging market.

"The Union government's policy of auctioning coal blocks has enabled many private companies to enter the sector, competi-

ting public sector enterprises to compete in an increasingly competitive market," he said.

Vikramarka said SCCL must improve quality, enhance efficiency, reduce operational costs and offer better services than private players to remain competitive.

SPOTLIGHT PAPER LEAK

Bill proposes ₹10 cr fine, 10-year jail

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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday approved a draft bill that will pave the way for harsher punishments—such as a jail term of up to 10 years and stiffer penalties of up to ₹10 crore—for those convicted of paper leaks, said people aware of the details.

The draft bill will amend The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, proposing a minimum punishment of five years' imprisonment for individuals involved in paper leaks, the people cited above said.

The draft bill, which Modi mentioned in his video message late on Thursday night, will now be tabled in the Lok Sabha on Monday, said a person privy to the details.

The present law has provisions for three to five years' imprisonment for individuals involved in paper leaks and a minimum fine of ₹1 crore for those involved in the organised crime of cheating and paper leaks.

The bill aims to prevent organised gangs and institutions that indulge in unfair means for monetary gains while protecting the candidates from its provisions.

"PM Modi underscored in his message that there will be strict action against those involved in paper leaks and that no candidate will go unpunished," said a person privy to the details.

The government is also likely to provide statutory backing for special fast track courts, whose mandate will be to dispose off matters and announce punishment within three months, the people cited above said.

"We are preparing to present the bill, but after you receive the briefing on our cabinet decision, we will inform you about our timing," a prime minister's aide said that there should be no delay in the bill as we are bringing regarding students. The country also wants what the prime minister has said that the future will be right to resort to any tactics to obstruct it," Union parliament

Anti-leak laws across states

STATE AND NAME OF THE ACT	ENACTED ON	PENALTY FOR LEAKS, SYNDICATES	PENALTY FOR UNFAIR MEANS
Odisha Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024	Feb 2025	3 to 10 years in jail; ₹1 crore fine	3 to 10 years in jail, ₹10 lakh fine
Uttarakhand Competitive Examination (Measures for Control and Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2023	Feb 2023	Life imprisonment and up to ₹10 crore fine	3-year jail and up to ₹5 lakh fine, and students barred for 2-5 years
Uttar Pradesh Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024	Jul 2024	Life term, property seizure and up to ₹1 crore fine	2 years in jail in jail, ₹1 crore fine
Chhattisgarh (Lok Bhatti Evam Vyavasayi Parishad me Anuchit Sadhano Ki Rokhtam) Vidhaya, 2026	Mar 2026	Up to 10 years in jail, ₹1 crore fine, and property seizure	3 years in jail and up to ₹1 crore fine
Assam Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2024	Mar 2024	5 to 10 years in jail, and fine between ₹10 lakh-₹10 crore	Up to 3 years in jail, ₹1 lakh fine
Arunachal Pradesh Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2024	Aug 2024	Up to 5 years in jail and fine up to ₹1 crore	3 to 5 years in jail and up to ₹1 crore fine
Jharkhand Competitive Examination (Measures for Control and Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2023	Nov 2023	Life imprisonment and up to ₹10 crore fine	Up to 7 years in jail and up to ₹1 crore fine
Rajasthan Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2022	Apr 2022	5-10 years in jail; fine between ₹10 lakh and ₹10 crore	3-year jail and at least ₹1 lakh fine
Haryana Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2021	Sept 2021	7 to 10 years in jail, fine not less than ₹10 crore	7 years in jail, up to ₹10 lakh fine
Bihar Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024	Aug 2024	Up to 10 years in jail and up to ₹1 crore fine	3-5 years in jail, up to ₹10 lakh fine
Gujarat Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2023	Mar 2023	7 to 10 years in jail and a minimum fine of ₹1 crore	10-year jail, up to ₹1 crore fine
Maharashtra Prevention of Malpractices at University, Board and Other Specified Examinations Act, 1982 and the Maharashtra Competitive Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 1991	Jul 2024	Up to 5 years in jail and ₹1 crore fine	3 to 5 years in jail and up to ₹10 lakh fine
Andhra Pradesh Public Examinations (Prevention of Malpractices and Unfair Means) Act, 2024	Aug 1997	3 to 7 years in jail and a fine ranging from ₹5,000 to ₹1 lakh	Same punishment as leaks
Himachal Pradesh Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Bill, 2025	Nov 2025	3 to 10 years in jail and up to ₹1 crore fine	3-5 years in jail, up to ₹10 lakh fine

tary affairs minister Kiren Rijju said.

"The Congress will fall into this if they continue to disrupt the parliamentary proceedings. We are taking important steps to ensure that while protecting the candidates from its provisions, the Congress party continues to create all kinds of hurdles to prevent parliamentary discussion, then they will have to face the brunt of the youth of this nation and, in fact, the entire nation," he added.

The Opposition has signalled that it will not allow Parliament to function if Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan does not resign.

Reacting to the PM's video message on Thursday, Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge posted on X: "Before coming to Parliament today, come after dismissing Dharmendra Pradhan. First, apologise to the students and take strict action against those who ordered the use of lathis, batons, and pellet guns to suppress the students' voices. Then we are ready for a detailed discussion on the education system."

NTA sacks 47 officials in major overhaul

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has terminated the services of 47 officials in what is being described as a "major overhaul" of the agency following a series of examination controversies, including the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, people familiar with the matter said on Friday.

The action comes amid continuing student protests at Jantar Mantar demanding the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in NEET.

Apart from the dismissals, legal and criminal proceedings are likely to be initiated against some officials based on findings of internal inquiries and inputs from investigating agencies, the people said.

The NTA is yet to disclose the names, ranks or specific reasons behind the dismissals.

The overhauling of the agency is part of a wider restructuring of

APART FROM THE DISMISSALS, LEGAL AND CRIMINAL PROCEEDINGS ARE LIKELY TO BE INITIATED AGAINST SOME OFFICIALS.

the examination body in line with the recommendations of the High-Level Committee of Experts (HLCE) headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan. The seven-member panel constituted in June 2024 had submitted its report on October 2, and recommended replacing NTA's contractual workforce with permanent, accountable staff.

As part of the exercise, the agency has invited applications for four newly created general manager posts covering assessment research and psychometrics, test centre network and operations, information security, and vigil-

ance, investigation and forensics. It has also advertised 16 young professional officers, three directors, one research scientist (C), and one senior superintendent (Accounts).

In May, it advertised three special leadership roles—chief technology officer, chief finance officer and general manager (human resources)—to strengthen governance and modernise its operations.

The overhaul will also extend to examination delivery in the coming years. From 2027, NEET-UG will be conducted in computer-based mode, replacing the current pen-and-paper format.

More than 2.2 million candidates appeared for the NEET-UG 2026 test on June 2 last after the original May 3 examination was cancelled over a paper leak. CBI, which is investigating the case under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 and other laws, has arrested 13 people and is expected to file its charge sheet later this month.

senior positions including three joint secretaries, two deputy directors, one research scientist (C), and one senior superintendent (Accounts). In May, it advertised three special leadership roles—chief technology officer, chief finance officer and general manager (human resources)—to strengthen governance and modernise its operations.

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CPJ(ML) MLA held in connection with AISA protests in Patna: Cops

PATNA: CPJ(ML) Liberation MLAs Sandeep Suarab, was detained in Patna on Friday, in connection to the All India Students Association's protests in the city on Wednesday, police said, adding that he has been charged of attempt to murder, intimidation and snatching of gold ornaments. In a video, he alleged that the police were trying to intimidate students.

MAN SAYS FORCED TO DELETE POSTS SEEKING POLICE BRUTALITY PROOF

AHMEDABAD: A 28-year-old software developer who created an online database to document alleged police brutality during the July 20 Chalo Sanaad' march said he was briefly detained by Gujarat Police's Cyber Crime Branch and pressured to delete social media posts in which people submitted evidence. Police denied the charges, saying he was neither detained nor forced to remove any content.

The developer told HT that he launched the website on July 21 after seeing posts alleging violence by security personnel, particularly those without name badges, during clashes between protesters and police in Delhi. "As a developer, this was the least I could do for students. On July 21, I posted on Instagram about the database and my post was deleted. I could have been arrested. I asked if I could leave without deleting. He didn't reply. I understood they were manipulating me. I had to delete the posts".

A senior Ahmedabad Crime Branch official denied the allegations, saying the developer was only called for questioning and voluntarily deleted the posts. "He was neither detained nor was any case registered against him," the official said.

U'khand cop who 'resigned' at CPJ stir was already suspended: Police

DEHRADUN: Uttarakhand Police on Friday clarified that constable Sher Singh, whose claim of having resigned at the ongoing protest by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar was shared widely online, was already suspended and facing disciplinary action in connection to a criminal case against him over alleged organised land-grabbing activities.

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NEW DELHI: Activist Sonam Wangchuk's wife, Gitanjali J. Prasad, on Friday, alleged that people asked to rush to judge him for saying that he 26-day hunger strike, ending his he had paid a heavy physical price for a cause larger than himself and deserved compassion rather than criticism.

The appeal came hours after the Union government expressed hope that Wangchuk's decision will pave the way for ending the ongoing protests over paper leaks.

In a post on X, Angmo said: "Before you rush to criticise him, please first pause to earn the ethos of fasting for 26 days for a cause larger than yourself."

He said: "He lies in the ICU today, having lost 11 kg, including muscle mass, because he chose sacrifice over comfort. The least we can offer him is a day of compassion before burdening him with our own expectations and political calculations."

Appealing for compassion, Angmo added, "Not everyone is qualified to judge a life of selfless sacrifice. The first must earn the moral stature and do so. Please... Have a heart."

Wangchuk broke his fast shortly after midnight on Thursday in the presence of Union ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh. CJP convenor Abhijeet Dikhe, who is spearheading the protest the activist was supporting, hit Wangchuk's first pause to earn their protest demanding education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation will continue.

At least two senior BJP leaders and lawmakers said Wangchuk's call for dialogue is a welcome

Sejal Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey on Friday claimed that the Indian government wants his Bluetooth-based messaging app Bitchat taken down, sharing the app's code with the official government order by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Union ministry of home affairs, directing GitHub to remove access to the app's source code.

"The government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down," Dorsey wrote on X. The screenshots shared by Dorsey show a notice dated July 23, purportedly issued by the I4C. The order directs GitHub to remove or disable access to the repositories related to Bitchat within three hours.

The post comes as authorities have repeatedly suspended mobile internet services around Delhi's Jantar Mantar, where protests have been underway for several days. The government has issued six internet shutdown orders over the past five days, directing tech companies to block mobile internet within a 1.5-km radius of the protest site until Friday midnight. No extension order beyond July 26 has been issued. GitHub had issued a Friday evening, according to people aware of the matter.

Sonam Wangchuk

move. "He has already shown the way, they should listen to him and have a dialogue," said a leader. In his statement posted on X, Wangchuk said his decision to end his indefinite fast was taken in view of the protest by leading a dialogue and also did not want to put any additional conditions," the functionary said.

While the Opposition is also pushing for Pradhan's resignation, functionary privy to the details said, his wife, Gitanjali Angmo was instrumental. "She was the intermediary between the government and Wangchuk. She was very upset that he went back on his word so she convinced him to call off the fast. She was in favour of ending the protest by joining a dialogue and also did not want to put any additional conditions," the functionary said.

While the Opposition is also pushing for Pradhan's resignation, functionary privy to the details said, his wife, Gitanjali Angmo was instrumental. "She was the intermediary between the government and Wangchuk. She was very upset that he went back on his word so she convinced him to call off the fast. She was in favour of ending the protest by joining a dialogue and also did not want to put any additional conditions," the functionary said.

India issued takedown notice on Bluetooth chat app, says Dorsey

Sejal Sharma
letters@hindustantimes.com

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The screenshots shared by Jack Dorsey show a notice issued by I4C AGAINST BITCHAT, AN OFFLINE MESSENGER

The government targeted Bitchat as protesters turned to it to stay connected amid the internet shutdown at Jantar Mantar following repeated mobile internet suspensions. Unconventional messaging apps, Bitchat does not require an internet connection. Instead, it uses Bluetooth to create a mesh network that allows nearby devices to exchange messages directly.

The I4C's notice says Bitchat's architecture makes lawful interception, attribution and investigations by law enforcement agencies significantly more difficult. It says decentralised communication platforms could be exploited by anti-national elements, terrorist organisations, organised crime groups and cybercriminals.

The government has not publicly commented on the claims or whether police officials had also not publicly responded at the time of writing.

MAMATA MAY JOIN CPJ PROTEST IN DELHI ON MONDAY

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: Trinamool Congress (TMC) chief and former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee is likely to join the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest against the alleged NEET paper leak at Jantar Mantar on Monday, people familiar with the matter said.

Banerjee is expected to visit the protest site to express solidarity with the students participating in the agitation, they said.

A senior TMC leader, requesting anonymity, said, "Banerjee will join the CJP's protest in Delhi on Monday."

Her participation in what has become one of the largest student-led protests in the national capital is also being seen as an attempt to underline the NTA's relevance at a time when the party has faced setbacks in both Parliament and the West Bengal assembly.

In a post on X, she wrote: "I have stood firmly with the students and their movement from the very beginning. Their fight is not just for justice in the NEET exam—it is a fight to protect the future of every young Indian. The entire Opposition, along with the entire nation, stands firmly with our students, their dreams and youth."

She had earlier indicated that she was planning to join the protest on Monday if required.

announced later. Internet services were suspended in Bihar's Muzaffarpur town for two days following a nationwide strike in support of protesting CPJ's demand. The state government asked Muzaffarpur district administration to impose the ban until 10 am on July 26.

Police in Kolkata on Friday ordered CPJ's demand that the state government asked Muzaffarpur district administration to impose the ban until 10 am on July 26. Police in Kolkata on Friday ordered CPJ's demand that the state government asked Muzaffarpur district administration to impose the ban until 10 am on July 26. Police in Kolkata on Friday ordered CPJ's demand that the state government asked Muzaffarpur district administration to impose the ban until 10 am on July 26.

Oppo may finalise paper leak bill stand on Monday

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Centre's plan to enact stringent legislation against examination paper leaks faces an Opposition blockade in Parliament unless the government accedes its demand to dismiss education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, leaders of several parties told HT on Friday.

Opposition parties have called a meeting on Monday to take a final decision on the proposed law. Leaders from various parties said on Friday that their protests over student issues take precedence over allowing the passage of the bill, which they argued would give the government an upper hand.

Addressing the Prime Minister's video message on Thursday night, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said, "Before coming to Parliament today, come after dismissing Dharmendra Pradhan. First, apologise to the students and take strict action against those who ordered the use of lathis, batons, and pellet guns to suppress the students' voices. Then we are ready for a detailed discussion on the education system."

Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi said, "I would like to say clearly the stance of Opposition—the students have three demands: (1) Corrupt education officer and general manager (human resources)—to strengthen governance and modernise its operations. (2) Action against those who attacked students and beat them up. (3) PM should apologise to the students. These are the three conditions. We are not going to have any conversation, any discussion before Pradhan is sacked. That's it."

All India Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Derek O'Brien said, "It is now way beyond just dropping a minister. The Prime Minister and the home minister are accountable. The Opposition is completely dismissive of such stunts like the bill."

Communist Party of India (Marxist) lawmaker John Brittas said, "We have no problem with any legislation to strengthen the exam system. But action should precede legislation. Dharmendra Pradhan must resign before the discussion starts on the bill."

Some Opposition leaders, how-



Opposition parties have called a meeting on Monday to take a final call on the proposed law.

ever, maintained that while Pradhan's resignation remains a non-negotiable condition, stalling measures to tighten laws against paper leaks carries political risks.

A former home minister rejected one of the proposed provisions—setting up fast-track courts—to students and our demand for a debate on NEET paper scams would invariably be covered in the debate. The government wants to kill two birds with one stone. We would not allow that."

"Rahul Gandhi has hit the roads to demand the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan. West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee is joining the protests. Under these circumstances, there is no scope of a compromise with the government," a senior Rajya Sabha leader said.

"We are preparing to present the bill, but after you receive the briefing on our cabinet decision, we will inform you about our timing. The Prime Minister has said that there should be no delay in the bill as we are bringing regarding students. The country also wants what the prime minister has said that the future will be right to resort to any tactics to obstruct it," Kiren Rijju said.

Pradhan 'criminal ed minister,' says Rahul

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Friday intensified his attack on Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, calling him a "criminal education minister" and demanding his removal over exam paper leaks, as he presented before the media a student protester allegedly hit by a pellet during the July 20 protests in the capital.

Gandhi also demanded action against security personnel accused of using pellet guns and batons against protesters, and called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi to apologise to students.

Addressing reporters outside Congress Party's headquarters, Party chief Sonam Wangchuk said, "I am a resident. Gandhi stood alone at Sahil, a 19-year-old Delhi University student who alleged that he was hit in the right eye by a pellet while participating in a peaceful protest." Dharmendra Pradhan is a criminal education minister. He has to be removed. He is a symbol of the collapse of our education system. He has to go," Gandhi said.

Showing Sahil's injuries to reporters, Gandhi said the government had to police the protesters and the student was contradicted by the student's condition.

In a social media post, later, Gandhi said Sahil works part-time to support his family. He said Sahil had been a police force recruitment exam but the question paper was leaked.



LOP Rahul Gandhi with a victim of alleged pellet gun firing.

"The government has claimed that no pellet guns were used, but look at this. This person has suffered an eye injury and has lost vision in one eye. These young people are the future of India. Thousands of youths were allegedly hit by pellet guns, lathi-charged, beaten and assaulted, and this is the government's response. A peaceful protest," he said.

Gandhi said students were protesting because of repeated examination paper leaks. "They worked hard for years to prepare for examinations, only to be told that the paper had been leaked. Those who had ₹60-70 lakh could buy the question paper, while the rest were left to struggle."

In a social media post, later, Gandhi said Sahil works part-time to support his family. He said Sahil had been a police force recruitment exam but the question paper was leaked.

In Chennai, protesters demanded NEET's abolition. The protest was led by CPJ's Tamil Nadu unit and students' Federation of India (SFI).

Protest rallies were also reported from Goa as well with Azad Mahila and a panel Panaji becoming the gathering point for demonstrators.

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NEW DELHI: Student-led protests, called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demanding the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak, were reported from several cities on Friday amid heavy police deployment, snapping of internet connections and school shutdowns.

Placard-wielding students and teachers gathered at important intersections in cities like Nagpur, Kolkata and Haldwani, demanding the minister's resignation and a complete overhaul of the education system.

any of the demonstrations.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency cancelled National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test Undergraduate (NEET UG-2026) held on May 3 following paper leak allegations. A re-examination was held on June 2.

In Telangana, all educational institutions remained closed on Friday as a state-wide strike called by several student organisations disrupted academic activities. The protesters demanded the alleged police baton-charge on students demonstrating in New Delhi. SN Reddy, president of the Telangana Recognised Private Schools Association, said the majority of nearly 3,500 private schools within the Greater Hyderabad Municipal



A protest march in Kolkata on Friday.

Corporation limits remained closed. Dhanu University, Jawahar Nehru Technological University and Kaloji Narayana Rao University of Health Sciences postponed examinations scheduled for Friday, stating that revised examination dates would be

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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Oppn: No house business till Pradhan quits

HT Correspondents

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NEW DELHI: The Opposition's demand for education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation washed out the first week of the monsoon session of Parliament, with no resolution in sight to break the deadlock between the government and opposition parties.

With 14 working days remaining in the session, Opposition parties have scheduled a meeting on Monday to strategise for the week ahead. Senior leaders indicated they are unlikely to relent on their demand for Pradhan's removal, even as the government prepares to introduce legislation against examination paper leaks.

Demanding Pradhan's resignation, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge posted on X on Friday: "Before coming to Parliament today, come after dismissing Dharmendra Pradhan. First, apologise to the students and take strict action against those who ordered the use of lathis, batons, and Pellet Guns to suppress the students' voices. Then we are ready for a detailed Discussion on the education system."

Kharge was responding to a video message delivered on Thursday by the Prime Minister, who announced a new bill to tackle paper leaks.

The Union government said on Friday it has reached out to the Opposition to end the stalemate over a proposed discussion on

paper leaks. The government requested Opposition support to pass the bill, which contains provisions for harsher punishments and heavier penalties for paper leaks and related offences.

"We will table the bill on Monday in the Lok Sabha. And we expect the opposition to help us pass the bill that has been designed to address the concerns of the students. They have been protesting for reforms so let them come together on this issue," a senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) lawmaker said.

Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju said government efforts to break the parliamentary logjam remain ongoing. "I have been speaking to the floor leaders and requesting them to agree to taking up legislative work. They wanted a discussion on the paper leaks but have not let that happen," he said.

As the Opposition hardened its stance, government efforts to initiate a discussion on the Vande Mataram Bill failed in the Rajya Sabha on Friday. Opposition members refused to permit legislative business prior to Pradhan's resignation. "We've seen their stance on Vande Mataram that no one should have any objection to. We do expect that they will create ruckus on Monday as well, which is why the government wants to table the bill as soon as the House convenes," the BJP lawmaker cited in the first instance said.

Demanding Pradhan's resignation, Congress president Mallikar-

jun Kharge posted on X on Friday: "Before coming to Parliament today, come after dismissing Dharmendra Pradhan. First, apologise to the students and take strict action against those who ordered the use of lathis, batons, and Pellet Guns to suppress the students' voices. Then we are ready for a detailed Discussion on the education system."

Kharge was responding to a video message delivered on Thursday by the PM, who announced a new bill to tackle paper leaks.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi too reiterated that Pradhan's resignation, police accountability, and an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi are non-negotiable conditions for resuming normal business.

Responding to Rijiju's statement, Gandhi said, "Just now, minister Rijiju made a statement that he wants to tell our MPs that there should be a discussion. Normal protocol says that if someone mentions someone else's name, they are responded to. When I wanted to respond, my mic was taken away. I wasn't given the opportunity. But I would like to say clearly the stance of Opposition - 1) Corrupt education minister has to go, 2) Action against those who attacked students and beat them up, 3) PM should apologise to the students. These are the 3 conditions. We are not going to have any conversation, any discussion before Pradhan is sacked. That's it."

Bill to 'safeguard' Vande Mataram introduced

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NEW DELHI: Union minister of state (MoS) for home affairs Nityanand Rai, on Friday, tabled the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the Rajya Sabha, proposing criminal penalties for anyone who deliberately disrupts or prevents the singing of Vande Mataram.

The proposed amendment seeks to expand the scope of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, by bringing within its ambit acts of intentionally obstructing the rendition of the national song or creating disturbances during its singing.

The government argued that the legislation is intended to safeguard the dignity of Vande Mataram, which played a defining role in India's freedom movement. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Seth welcomed the proposal, saying the national song has gained wider acceptance in recent years and deserves the same level of public respect.

The Opposition, however, questioned the constitutional validity of the move, contending that it could encroach upon



Nityanand Rai

fundamental rights.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) Rajya Sabha member John Brittas had, ahead of the Bill's introduction, written to Union home minister Amit Shah urging the government to reconsider the proposal.

In his letter dated July 19, Brittas said that while Vande Mataram remains an iconic symbol of the Independence movement, equating its rendition with criminal liability marks a departure from the constitutional treatment of the National Anthem and the National Song.

He argued that the proposed amendment raises issues relating to Articles 19, 21 and 25 of the Constitution, which protect freedom of speech and expression, personal liberty and freedom of conscience. AAP MP Sanjay Singh also opposed the bill.

HC junks ANI's plea against OpenAI's use of its content

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Friday dismissed news agency ANI's petition seeking to restrain OpenAI from using its content to train ChatGPT without a licence, holding that the US firm's use of the material fell under a statutory exception for fair dealing.

Justice Amit Bansal ruled that the data used to train OpenAI's large language models was accessible only to the models themselves and not to the public for viewing or downloading, and that this qualified as private use under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act, 1957. The court held that OpenAI could invoke the fair-dealing defence despite the commercial nature of its operations.

"Open AI stores the literary works in a closed space without access to the public. The data obtained by the LLMs for training purposes is used for private purposes," the court said in its 135-page verdict, adding that both the purpose test and the fairness test under the provision stood satisfied.

The HC order runs counter to a string of recent rulings and settlements elsewhere that have gone against AI firms on copyright. In the latest, a federal judge in US this month granted final approval to a \$1.5 billion settlement in Bartz vs Anthropic — the largest copyright

THE COURT SAID THAT GRANTING AN INTERIM INJUNCTION WOULD HURT THE GROWTH OF AI IN INDIA

recovery in US history — after an earlier ruling found that while training AI on legally acquired books could be fair use, using pirated "shadow libraries" to build the dataset was not, forcing Anthropic to pay roughly \$3,000 per affected work and destroy the pirated material.

In Friday's order, the court said granting an interim injunction at this stage would hurt the growth of artificial intelligence in India and adversely affect millions of ChatGPT users, many of whom do not pay for the service.

The interim application was filed as part of ANI's broader copyright infringement suit against OpenAI, in which the news agency has sought a permanent restraint on the use of its content, deletion of stored material, and damages of ₹2 crore. ANI had alleged that OpenAI trained its models on its content without a licence, commercially exploiting its work.

OpenAI, represented by senior advocate Amit Sibal, had argued that large language models do not

store third-party text but generate new responses to avoid regurgitation, and that ChatGPT functions merely as an interface between users and content. Sibal said the model's storage of ANI's content was for private use and fell within fair use.

The court had appointed two experts to assist it. Professor Arul George Scaria of the National Law School of India University argued that OpenAI's storage of ANI's data for training did not amount to infringement, while advocate Adarsh Ramanujan maintained that the act of copying the data without consent was itself infringing, unless justified under fair use.

An OpenAI spokesperson welcomed the ruling, saying: "ChatGPT helps enhance human creativity, advance scientific discovery and medical research. Our models empower innovation, and are trained on publicly available data and grounded in the principles of fair dealing."

In 2025, a Delaware court ruled that Ross Intelligence's use of Thomson Reuters' Westlaw content to train a competing AI tool was not fair use, the first US ruling to reject that defence in an AI case.

In Europe, France's competition authority fined Google €250 million in 2024 for breaching prior transparency commitments to publishers after training its Bard chatbot on their content without notice.

UP woman's husband shot her dead in SUV she gifted him: Police

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MEERUT: Investigators probing the disappearance of a 23-year-old woman from Uttar Pradesh's Moradabad district said on Friday that her husband has confessed to shooting her inside an SUV she gifted him and then dumping her body in Uttarakhnad.

The victim, identified as Adila Rahman, was reportedly missing since June 25, when left her home to purportedly appear for her second-year LLB examinations at Hyderabad's Osmania University.

Adila's body was recovered from a canal in Haridwar district's Mangaur by local police on July 4 and subsequently cremated after her identity could not be established, said police.

The accused, identified as Gulam Ali, is currently lodged at Rampur district jail in connection with an attempted murder case from 2025, said Moradabad SP (city) Ranvijay Singh. He surrendered in Rampur on July 1. Singh added that Gulam allegedly confessed to the murder while in jail. "We have applied for police custody remand of the accused," he said, adding that investigators were tracing the

THE ACCUSED IS CURRENTLY IN RAMPUR JAIL IN CONNECTION WITH AN ATTEMPTED MURDER CASE, SAID POLICE

murder weapon and the SUV. Investigators said Adila and Gulam allegedly eloped in Rajasthan's Ajmer district and were living in Noida. He allegedly attributed her purported insistence of his severing all family ties to the deterioration of their relationship, they added. After Adila's family found their marriage certificate at home, they lodged a kidnapping complaint against Gulam on July 18.

The murder reportedly occurred on July 29 after Adila hired a taxi from Delhi to return to Moradabad after an argument. Gulam allegedly intercepted her in Joya, where the argument resumed. Upon reaching an old toll plaza on the Delhi-Lucknow Highway, he allegedly shot her at close range, killing her on the spot, said police. He then allegedly drove to Uttarakhnad and disposed of the body.

12 BLOs DIED IN K'TAKA SINCE S.I.R COMMENCED: CEO

BENGALURU: Twelve booth level officers (BLOs) deployed for Karnataka's Special Intensive Revision exercise have died since the exercise began on June 30, chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anbukumar said on Friday.

"There is no provision under the Election Commission's guidelines to provide compensation to the families of BLOs who die while on duty," he said, and added that he was unaware of the causes of death. Deaths were reported in multiple districts. Bhuvana, a village administrative officer supervising BLOs, was killed on Saturday in a road accident in Tumakuru district while travelling for SIR-related work.

In Bidar district, 45-year-old Sumil, a government school teacher deployed in Bhalvi, suffered a heart attack and collapsed at work on Thursday and was taken to the Bidar Institute of Medical Sciences, where he died the next day.

Both state Congress leader F H Jakkappa and state BJP chief BY Vijayendra have sought compensation for the deceased's families. **ARUN DEV**

2 KILLED IN BLAST AT SAHARANPUR FIREWORKS UNIT

MEERUT: At least two men were killed and two others reported missing after an explosion ripped through a fireworks factory in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur district on Friday, said police, adding that rescue operations were underway.

The deceased were identified as labourers Deepraj (22) and Sandeep (25), both from Indore in Madhya Pradesh. Witnesses said around 24 people were inside the factory in Naya Gaon when the blast took place at around 5pm.

Police said the factory owner, a resident of Ghaziabad, had left for Saharanpur after receiving information about the incident and was being questioned. "Rescue teams are searching the debris for trapped people, while the injured are being taken to hospitals," said Saharanpur SSP Abhinandan.

Police said the unit had been operating for the past five years. The SSP said efforts were underway to verify if the factory was operating legally.

SP (rural) Mayank Pathak said preliminary findings suggested negligence as the cause of the explosion. **HTC**

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SC puts curbs on sharing of court proceeding clips

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday restrained the extraction, editing, dissemination, reposting, uploading and monetisation of audio and video recordings of judicial proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission from the concerned court registrars, observing that courts cannot become a "24/7 entertainment channel" and that access to virtual hearings requires regulation and a careful balancing of transparency with the administration of justice.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyymaya Bagchi and V Mohana, passed the interim order while issuing notice on a public interest litigation seeking safeguards against the misuse of livestreamed court proceedings through selective clipping, sensationalised circulation and commercial exploitation on digital platforms.

"As an interim measure, it is directed that there shall be no extraction, modification, monetisation, posting, reposting or uploading of audio-video recordings of judicial proceedings on social media or other platforms without permission of the secretary general of the Supreme Court or the registrar general of the jurisdictional high courts," directed the bench.



SC said courts cannot be 24/7 entertainment channel.

The court ordered that the secretary general of the Supreme Court and the registrars general of all high courts display the interim direction prominently on their official websites. It clarified that the embargo will not apply to news reporting of court proceedings.

The interim order came on a petition filed by journalist Harshita Grover, who sought formulation of guidelines regulating the clipping, editing, redistribution and monetisation of audiovisual recordings of court proceedings. The plea contended that while livestreaming was introduced to further the principles of open justice and transparency, the absence of safeguards had enabled courtroom exchanges to be taken out of context, circulated with misleading captions and exploited for commercial gain.

During the hearing, senior advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for the petitioner, clarified that the challenge was not to livestreaming itself but to the rampant misuse of

edited clips on social media.

"I personally don't see any problem with livestream," submitted Singh even as he referred to instances where selective clips of court hearings had gone viral. The SCBA president referred to the recent disruption before Justice KV Viswanath's bench, where judicial proceedings were thrown into disarray after papers were hurled inside the courtroom and abusive language was allegedly used, arguing that clipped videos of such incidents were being circulated widely on social media.

At this, the bench remarked that regulating digital content had become "one of the biggest challenges" in the present era and suggested that unrestricted virtual access to court proceedings may require reconsideration.

"Regulating data is one of the biggest challenges in digital space...We should ensure limited access and therefore restrict livestream itself. Parties must expressly make a prayer that they want to see. It can't be a 24/7 entertainment channel by court," it said.

The court also pointed out that virtual hearing links are frequently shared indiscriminately, underscoring the need for regulation of online access as well.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta supported the plea for interim protection, warning that advances in artificial intelligence had significantly heightened the risks posed by manipulated recordings.

"Suppose your lordships are saying something to me and I am responding. There are AI tools. With the same lip movement, my and your lordships' words can be changed in our respective voices," submitted Mehta.

The CJ agreed that distorted reporting and misinformation had become a growing concern. Referring to recent media reports concerning a letter petition over alleged police excesses during student protests in Delhi, Justice Kant remarked that statements had been attributed to him that were never made.

Besides issuing notice to all high courts, the bench directed the Centre to identify the nodal ministries that would be responsible for implementing any future regulatory framework. It also called upon the high courts to submit reports on the implementation of the Supreme Court's livestreaming guidelines and explain the impact of continuous livestreaming of judicial proceedings.

Grover's petition contends that isolated courtroom exchanges and tentative oral observations are routinely extracted from lengthy hearings, stripped of legal and factual context and repackaged with sensational captions to maximise online engagement and advertising revenue. According to Grover, such practices expose judges, lawyers and litigants to trolling while creating distorted public perceptions of the judicial process.

FSSAI SUSPENDS NUTRACEUTICAL MAKER'S LICENCE

Rhythmika Kaul

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NEW DELHI: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on Friday suspended the manufacturer's licence of Rehaan Healthcare after inspections found that the regulator described as "critical non-compliance" and unhygienic conditions at the company's health supplement and nutraceutical manufacturing unit in Rehaan Healthcare, which manufactures digestive syrups, multivitamin syrups and other syrup-based food products, has been directed to stop production until all deficiencies are rectified and verified by the competent authority, FSSAI said in a statement.

Established in 2018 and based in Mohali, Rehaan Healthcare says on its website that it provides "scalable third-party manufacturing solutions".

FSSAI's inspection found the manufacturing premises to be "extremely unhygienic and unorganised". The report flagged food safety officers found spider webs, mould growth, flies, insects and exposed food waste inside the manufacturing area. "Sediments of filth and sludge accumulated under the manufacturing tank, disorganised storage of raw materials and poor housekeeping created a serious risk of cross-contamination," it added.

FSSAI has directed the company to immediately stop all food business activities until the deficiencies are corrected. HT has reached out to the firm but did not get a response till the time of print.

SC proposes special courts to hear Manipur violence cases

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday mooted the idea of constituting special courts to conduct day-to-day trials into the 2023 Manipur violence cases and directed the probe agencies to expedite the complete investigation into all pending cases within a reasonable time.

The order was passed by a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant in a batch of petitions for monitoring the issues of investigation into the criminal cases, relief and rehabilitation of victims and those displaced due to the ethnic violence in the state.

The bench also comprising justices Joyymaya Bagchi and V Mohana said, "We tentatively propose to constitute special courts, with the concurrence of the Manipur government and the high courts of Manipur and Gauhati so that trials in these cases can be taken up on a day-to-day basis, especially in view of the inordinate

THE STATE POLICE SITs ARE PROBING 3,020 CASES WHILE CBI IS PROBING ONLY 31 CASES

delay in the ongoing investigations. Posting the matter after two weeks, the court directed the two probe agencies to "do their best" to complete the pending investigations.

The criminal cases emanating from the violence are being probed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the special investigation teams (SIT) constituted by the state police. Two reports were submitted by a respective agencies in sealed cover which showed that several SITs are investigating 3,020 cases across the eight districts in the state while CBI is probing only 31 cases involving heinous offences of murder and rape.

The court was informed that

the SITs have completed investigation in only 301 cases and trial has commenced in respect of 11 cases. There are 2,924 witnesses to be examined and charges have been framed only in 31 cases.

The CBI status report points out that in 21 cases, investigation is complete although supplementary investigation is still continuing in 11 cases. Six closure reports were filed of which three have been accepted by the designated court. Investigation in four cases is still pending.

The court also dealt with individual applications filed by church organisations claiming that for nearly three years, the damaged church buildings have not been reconstructed. The court said that this matter could be handled by a judge committee headed by former high court judge justice (retd) Gita Mittal.

The court extended the term of the committee till December 31, 2026 and sought further status reports to be filed by CBI and SIT by the next date of hearing.

Govt urges SC to let ret'd judges hear new water disputes

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Union government has moved the Supreme Court seeking a "purposive" interpretation of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956, to allow retired Supreme Court and high court judges heading existing water tribunals to adjudicate fresh inter-state river disputes, arguing that such a reading would avoid the need to constitute new tribunals each time and ensure quicker resolution of disputes.

In an application filed before a bench of justices Vikram Nath and

Sandeep Mehta, the Centre urged the court to interpret Section 4(2) of the Act to hold that the statutory requirement that the chairman and members of a water disputes tribunal be nominated by the Chief Justice of India "from among persons who at the time of such nomination are Judges of the Supreme Court or of a High Court" is only a threshold qualification and not a continuing condition.

The plea, pressed by Attorney General R Venkataramani on Friday, seeks modification of the Supreme Court's February 2 judgment directing the Centre to constitute a tribunal to adjudicate the

THE PLEA SOUGHT MODIFICATION OF A FEB 2 JUDGMENT, DIRECTING SETTING UP OF A TRIBUNAL FOR PENNAYAR RIVER DISPUTE

long-pending Pennayar river water dispute between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka. Instead of setting up a fresh tribunal, the Union wants permission to assign the dispute to the already constituted Mahaday Water Disputes

Tribunal, whose members have since retired from the constitutional courts but continue to hold office under the statute.

Appearing for the Union, Venkataramani submitted that the government was "seeking a purposive interpretation of Section 4(2) of the Act so as to permit an existing Tribunal, whose members satisfied the qualification when nominated, to be entrusted with Pennayar dispute adjudication."

The bench questioned why Parliament had not amended the statutory framework if such flexibility was intended. "You should have amended the provision...it would

have been resolved by now," observed the bench, referring to the mandatory requirement under Section 4 that the Centre constitute a tribunal once negotiations fail.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for Karnataka along with advocate Nishanth Patil, 42 of the Act so as to permit an existing Tribunal, whose members satisfied the qualification when nominated, to be entrusted with Pennayar dispute adjudication."

The bench granted both states two weeks to file their replies and directed that the matter be listed thereafter.

Govt okays chemical parks scheme, expansion of K'taka-Andhra rly line

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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Friday approved the Bharat Aardrogya Vikas Yojana Rastagan (BHAVYA Rastagan) scheme with a financial outlay of ₹3,030 crore to establish three dedicated chemical parks across the country.

The scheme, which was announced in the Union Budget for FY2026-27, will have a total outlay of ₹3,030 crore, including ₹3,000 crore for developing common infrastructure and basic utilities inside the parks and ₹30 crore towards administrative expenditure.

The scheme will be implemented over five years, from FY2026-27 to FY2030-31.

"The Centre would provide a grant of up to ₹1,000 crore per park. This will be subject to a minimum contribution of ₹500 crore by the concerned State Government," according to an official release.

The Cabinet's approval of the

THE BHAVYA RASTAGAN SCHEME HAS AN OUTLAY OF ₹3,030 CRORE, WHILE THE RAIL LINE ON BALLARI - GUNTAKAL SECTION WILL BE BUILT AT THE COST OF ₹1,264 CRORE

BHAVYA-Rastagan Scheme marks an important step towards strengthening India's chemical and petrochemical ecosystem," Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on X.

In another decision, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Friday approved the construction of a 3rd and 4th rail line on the Ballari - Guntakal section in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh at a total cost of approximately ₹1,264 crore.

The project covering three districts across Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh will increase the existing Indian Railways network by about 46 km, the government said.

"The proposed multi-tracking project will enhance connectivity to approximately 99 villages, which are having a population of about seven lakhs. The capacity enhancement will improve rail connectivity to several prominent tourist destinations across the country, including Ballari Fort, Sri Kumara Swamy Temple," a statement from the government said.

It also stated that the proposed project is an essential route for transporting commodities such as iron ore, dolomite, limestone, iron and steel, coal, fertilizers, and food grains.

The capacity augmentation works will result in additional freight traffic of magnitude 16.22 Million Tonnes Per Annum," the government said, adding, the project is planned under PM-Gati Shakti National Master Plan.

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Saugata Ray to be TMC deputy leader in IS

NEW DELHI: Trinamool Congress appointed former Union minister and senior lawmaker Saugata Ray as its deputy leader in the Lok Sabha. The appointment comes after its earlier leadership — part of the 20 rebels — decided to merge with NCP and form a separate party. Ray was the Minister of State for Urban Development in the Mamohan Singh government and is widely regarded for his oratory skills.

Odisha journo's accounts frozen in extortion case
BHUBANESWAR: Odisha police have frozen four bank accounts linked to a regional television channel editor accused of running an extortion and blackmail racket under the guise of news reporting, while a special team has been dispatched outside Odisha to trace him, police said on Friday. A police officer said that they are examining the financial trail to determine the flow of funds and identify any proceeds from the alleged racket.

Motherhood sustains creation, says RSS chief
NEW DELHI: Hashitriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Friday described motherhood as the timeless foundation of creation, nurturing and continuity of life, asserting that while societies and eras may evolve, the essential values of motherhood remain unchanged and continue to shape civilisation. He was speaking at the conference on "Contemporary Motherhood".

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SHIMLA: Thirteen people, including a six-month-old infant, were killed after a massive boulder from a nearby hill suddenly crashed onto the SUV carrying them on the Udaipur-Killar road in Himachal Pradesh's Lahaul-Spiti district on Friday, officials aware of the matter said.

The deceased were identified as Veer Singh (35), Saurabh Singh (12), Veer Singh (driver), Bhudi Singh (46), Kamla Kumari (40), Anil Kumar (26), Rekha (25), Anjana, Sonam Angmo, Aravi (6 months), Sanjay, Mangal Chand and Inder Singh (45). The victims were travelling from Kullu to Pangl in Chamba district when large boulders came tumbling down near Kaddu Nala, around 60-70 km from Keylong, crushing the vehicle completely. All the victims were residents of the tribal Pangl Valley, said police.

Following the impact, the



The crushed wreckage of the SUV at the accident site on Friday.

SUV's rear portion caught fire. Locals and army personnel rushed to the spot and extinguished the flames before rescuers began removing the debris. One passenger was rescued alive but died en route to hospital, said officials.

Pangl resident commissioner Amandeep Singh said police and local administration teams rushed to the spot soon after receiving information about the incident.

Deputy commissioner and chairperson of the District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Lahaul-Spiti, Kiran Bhadana, said, "The passengers had reportedly spent the night at Tindi after the Udaipur-Killar road remained blocked on Thursday. They resumed their journey towards Pangl after the

road was reopened on Friday morning."

Bhadana said relief operations were launched immediately by the district administration, police, Border Roads Organisation (BRO) and other agencies.

A police team reached the site while BRO personnel continued clearing debris and carrying out search and rescue, she said.

"The process of identifying the deceased is underway and detailed information will be shared after official confirmation. The district administration is closely monitoring the situation and supervising relief efforts," the DDMA chairperson added.

Expressing grief over the deaths, chief minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu directed officials to provide all possible help to the families of the deceased. Bhamour MLA Janak Raj urged the deputy commissioners of Chamba, which is closer to the accident site, and Lahaul-Spiti to expedite relief operations.

ASSAM FLOODS
TOLL AT 47, CM
SAYS 80 MISSING

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SILCHAR: Six more people have died in Assam due to floods, taking the death toll in the disaster to 47.

According to Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, at least 70 to 80 people are still missing and the toll may rise further.

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), four deaths were reported from Nazim in Sivagang district and two from Mohmara in Chiraidoo district.

ASDMA's latest report said 721,024 people across 13 districts have been affected by the floods and 24,124 have taken shelter in relief camps. The state government is distributing relief materials through 358 relief distribution centres.

More democratic global trade law key to 'Viksit Bharat': EAM

Ayesha Arvind
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NEW DELHI: External affairs minister S Jaishankar on Friday said India's ambition of becoming a developed nation, its vision of "Viksit Bharat 2047," will depend on predictable and internationally compatible legal frameworks, and called for a more "democratic" global trade law architecture that reflects the priorities of developing countries.

Addressing an international conference marking the 60th anniversary of the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL) at the Supreme Court, Jaishankar said geopolitical volatility, supply chain disruptions and rapid technological change had transformed international commerce, making legal certainty as important as physical connectivity.

"What nations are seeking today is not merely infrastructure and connectivity, but, above all, legal predictability," he said. Countries, he added, needed harmonised, rules-based legal frame-



EAM S Jaishankar addresses the event held at the Supreme Court on Friday.

works that ensured seamless cross-border trade, data flows and enforcement of commercial contracts.

Jaishankar said UNCITRAL's work in developing model laws, conventions and legal standards had helped strengthen international trade by promoting harmonised legal frameworks, efficient dispute resolution and certainty in cross-border transactions.

He further said the vision of "Viksit Bharat 2047" was built on a resilient economy, technological innovation, expanded manufacturing and deeper integration with global markets. Realising that vision, Jaishankar said, required legal frameworks that inspired

confidence among investors and facilitated international trade and commercial cooperation.

The union minister also highlighted India's longstanding engagement with UNCITRAL and said that India was among the eight countries to have maintained continuous membership of the commission. He said "successive reforms in arbitration, commercial dispute resolution, and insolvency law" reflected India's commitment to building a "transparent and internationally compatible legal regime".

Jaishankar also said that international trade law must evolve alongside global economic shifts. "As the economic centre of gravity shifts, the legal architecture of tomorrow must be more democratic, inclusive and sensitive to the realities of the Global South."

Reiterating India's support for UNCITRAL's consensus-based approach, Jaishankar said UNCITRAL's next chapter should focus on ensuring that international trade law serves as a leveller, bridging the gap between developed and developing economies.

NSCN(IM) splits, faction announces autonomy

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KOIHMA: A group of leaders has broken away from the Isak-Muhleb National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN-IM) and announced the formation of a "provisional government". They claimed that the spirit of the ceasefire agreement with the Centre had "ceased to exist".

The new Eastern Flank faction said the decision was taken at an "extraordinary joint emergency meeting" held on July 21 at Mt Horeb Camp in Myanmar's Sagaing region. It said the move was aimed at "saving the nation from another surrender" and "rescuing the Naga political movement from its present predicament".

The group announced a nine-member "provisional government" headed by Ikato Chishi Swu, the son of late NSCN(IM) co-founder Isak Chishi Swu, as chairman and His Ramsan as vice chairman.

The elevation of Swu is likely to deepen the crisis of NSCN(IM), since it is construed as a challenge to the parent organisation's leader-

ship headed by Thuingaleng Muivah who is now over 90 years old. Swu had joined the Myanmar-based faction in April 2025, saying he had lost confidence in the present leadership of the group.

The breakaway faction also declared "null and void" the expulsion orders issued by the NSCN-IM leadership against Ramsan and Absalom Raman on June 24 and against Swu and four others on July 7.

"Those who have surrendered and yielded to the pressure of the government of India have no right to expel/terminate those who remain steadfast in striving for the sovereign existence of the Naga nation," the faction said.

The group rejected the "competencies" submitted by the NSCN-IM leadership to the Centre, alleging that they compromised the Naga political position by placing it within the Union and Constitution of India. It also accused the leadership of engaging in "meaningless and endless" talks and failing to act after what it described as the Centre's "betrayal" of the Framework Agreement signed on August 3, 2015.

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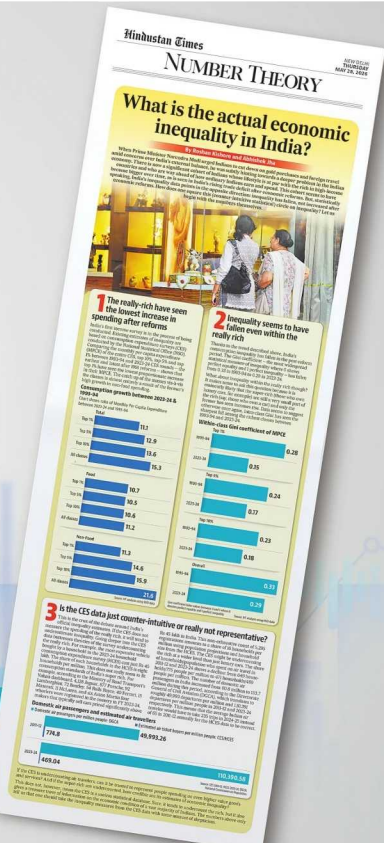
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Tariffs go, tariffs come...

Export diversification while continuing to engage with the US, and calibrated import substitution can hedge against their impact

The Trump administration has reimposed tariffs of 10-12.5% on 60 countries. India is included in the list and faces tariffs of 10%. This does not change things for India immediately as it already faced a 10% tariff rate after the US Supreme Court struck down Trump's Liberation Day and subsequent tariffs in February. An Indo-US trade deal is still in the works and it remains to be seen whether this wins greater relief for India. That India managed to escape the initially proposed 12.5% tariff suggests that negotiators have had some success with their US counterparts. These immediate details, however, offer little reprieve, in dealing with the US on trade matters. The crux of the problem lies in trying to treat a political problem with a judicial/technocratic approach. The judicial setback for Trump's Liberation Day tariffs was purely procedural, involving nitpicking over whether the executive had overreached in deciding matters that required legislative approval. The Trump administration has enough procedural loopholes to keep imposing new tariffs and continue to play whack-a-mole with the procedural remedy against such policies. Some of Trump's tariff policies are more intimidating than immediately punishing. This week's announcement that the US will impose tariffs of up to 200% on generic drugs two years down the line—India is a major exporter of these to the US—comes under this category. Expect this to be used as a bargaining chip in the ongoing Indo-US negotiations.

Unless Trump himself decides that tariffs are not an integral or useful part of his Make America Great Again political project, the problem and uncertainty will not go away. Most of the US's trade partners, India included, have little agency in shaping this view, but they must still engage with all such decisions to secure their short-term interests in the best possible manner. The Trump administration's actions in other areas, such as the ongoing war in West Asia, are only adding to economic pain in large parts of the world and making the trade shock even more painful.

Can there really be a strategy to deal with the US administration's approach at the moment? Deals, even after they have been negotiated with much difficulty, offer little comfort when the goalposts themselves keep changing. While there is no sure-shot solution to this problem, three guiding principles can be listed.

Export diversification away from the US, preferably based on merit rather than distress sale, is key. This will protect exporters in India, many of whom run small businesses, from sudden income shocks. India has done well to secure trade agreements with many other countries recently. Now it needs to ensure that these agreements actually help increase exports.

Also required is the macro pragmatism of continuing to engage with the world's largest economy and India's largest export market along with micro aggression in terms of taking on factually incorrect allegations such as widespread use of forced labour practices in India. This requires investment to increase our bandwidth for conducting such negotiations.

Last but not the least is the need for calibrated import substitution, of the efficiency enhancing rather than rent-seeking kind. If India's trade deficit in goods were to come down in the future, its dependence on export earnings from the US would be less of a macroeconomic concern. To say this is not to advocate autarky but emphasise the need to increase India's technological capabilities that can generate tailwinds for higher value addition in the domestic economy.

MINOR HINTS

Rahul Sagar

The severed limb that helped shape Bombay University

JP Hughlings collapsed from shock when an arm severed during an East India Company-ordered public execution landed on him. At Elphinstone College, he was also the educator who taught a generation that would one day challenge the Raj

On October 15, 1857, a *haidar* and a *spy* were marched onto the Esplanade in Bombay. Each was tied to the mouth of a cannon. The verdict—that they were guilty of plotting a “rising” against the British—was read out. A few moments later, before a large crowd, the guns were fired. As fate would have it, an arm, torn from one of the men, flew into the air and landed on the head of a young Englishman who promptly collapsed in shock. His name was JP Hughlings—and though he did not know it at the time, he was going to help the natives standing in the *maidan* mount a very different challenge to British rule.

Born to a working-class family in 1830, Hughlings had decided early in life to serve others, electing to attend Kneller Hall, a training college whose graduates were expected to administer schools for the children of paupers. However, the principal at Kneller Hall soon decided Hughlings deserved a better education and sent him to see Benjamin Jowett, the celebrated Oxford don. Jowett helped Hughlings into Oxford and subsequently recommended him to the East India Company any time when it sought faculty for the newly-expanded Elphinstone College. And so, only a few months after graduating in July 1856, Hughlings found himself aboard a ship to India, with the title of Professor of English for commerce.

When Hughlings arrived in Bombay, his plebeian background stood out in an environment populated by unburied “gentlemen” who owed their positions to family connections. He

was, a colleague sneered, “ill-made, slow-footed, short in stature, and endowed by nature with irregular and unhandsome features”. Worse still, he was much too “industrious”, spending his free time “sat at home reading Sanskrit and correcting the lecture books of the pupils who studied under him”.

This backbiting in Anglo-Indian society had no effect on Hughlings standing at Elphinstone where he quickly became “exceedingly popular”. To his students, he was the embodiment of virtues—past and present. Like the Hindu sages in their epics, he was selfless—a man who could have spent his weekends hobnobbing at Whites-only clubs but chose to spend them teaching his dark-skinned students the art of essay-writing. At the same time, like the Victorian sages in their textbooks, he did not live apart from the world. Not only was he an avid contributor to the press, he swept his students along, setting up a reading room for them and then paying hefty subscription fees for newspapers and periodicals such as *The Times* and *The Economist* out of his own pocket, in the hope that understanding the “questions of the day” would cultivate in them the “spirit of citizenship”.

As a result, even though he was only a little older than his students, Hughlings came to have an extraordinary influence upon them. By his own example, he taught them how to combine intellect and activity in the service of society—how words could remake worlds. It was a roster that included, among others, RG Bhandarkar, MG Ranade, NM Purnanand, KT Telang, VA Modak, and DE Wacha, to name only a few. Because of his “enormous capacity for hard work”, Hughlings also went on to play a “leading” role in the establishment of the University of Bombay, which celebrated its 160th anniversary this past week.

His toil was not always appreciated, however. He was passed over for the role of principal at Elphinstone, faulted not only because he was too naïveté to “project” himself, but also because his students discomfited British officials who began describing these worldly characters as “professional traitors” on account of their unsparring criticism of British India's administrative failures.



At Bombay's iconic Elphinstone College, Hughlings, by his own example, taught his students how to combine intellect and activity in the service of society.

HT ARCHIVE

In 1870, Hughlings suddenly succumbed to dysentery, the ailment that carried away many of his compatriots. But the “professional traitors” he had groomed at Elphinstone continued to grow in stature. Their ranks eventually included editors of newspapers, judges of the High Court, vice-chancellors of the University of Bombay, and presidents of the Indian National Congress—and they sang paeans to him to the end of their lives. Wacha, for instance, who went on to serve as president of the Congress in 1901, described Hughlings as the “ideal teacher” who had nurtured in him “a thirst for economics” and helped him become a prominent critic of British India's finances, through speeches and writings that drew attention to the embarrassing contrast between its generous expenditure on imperial projects and its paltry expenditure on social welfare.

Hughlings' short but productive life is worth recalling because it complicates our understanding of colonial rule. We mourn the men blown away at the Esplanade, and should recall, too, the shaker speaker who helped educate the generation that would challenge the Raj. We should also ponder what has become of institutions to which men like Hughlings devoted their lives. Even now, decades after Independence, our guides usually list colonial-era colleges and libraries as among the most notable sites in towns and cities of repute. But the condition of these historic structures, which housed teachers who, like Hughlings, made it their mission to show “kindness and friendship to the natives”, is pitiable. Designed to convey the ennobling nature of education, their

often-crumbling facades now symbolise bureaucratic apathy. In 2012, the University Grants Commission (UGC) inaugurated a scheme to grant colonial-era colleges “heritage status” and award them funds for preservation and restoration. Available reports indicate that only 19 colleges ever benefited from the scheme, and even in these cases, the funding offered was minuscule, amounting to about ₹1 crore in total. What can one hope for when the Archaeological Survey of India's (ASI) expenditure on conservation and restoration amounted to a mere ₹33 crore in 2024 and when nearly a third of its positions are vacant per a recent report? This leaves vital organisations like INTACH (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage) having to do much with little. A great deal comes to depend on philanthropic organisations—such as Tata Trusts, which has contributed twice toward the restoration of the Cowaji Jehangir Convocation Hall in the University of Bombay's iconic Victorian-era campus.

After Hughlings' death, his students, led by Telang, contributed generously from their still-paltry incomes to procure a handsome oil painting of their beloved teacher. The portrait's whereabouts are now unknown, leaving us with no trace whatsoever of Hughlings's visage. This disappearance is a metaphor for our time: We have come to the point where we have started to forget that we have forgotten.

Rahul Sagar is a Global Network associate professor at NYU Abu Dhabi. His latest book is *The Birth of Indian Liberalism*. The views expressed are personal

Myths and medicine on thyroid disorders

Every endocrinologist has encountered this conversation.

“Doctor, I've put on 12 kilos because of my thyroid.” Or this one: “My thyroid tests are normal now. Why should I continue taking medicine?” Or perhaps the commonest of all: “Do I really have to take this tablet for the rest of my life?”

Few endocrine disorders are as common, or as misunderstood, as hypothyroidism, which results from an underactive thyroid gland. In India, it affects an estimated 10-15% of adults, particularly women and older individuals. Yet much of what patients believe about the condition comes not from medical science but from social media, internet, or friends.

The thyroid is a small butterfly-shaped gland situated at the base of the neck. Despite its modest size, it exerts an extraordinary influence on the body by producing the hormones thyroxine (T4) and triiodothyronine (T3), under the effect of the thyroid stimulating hormone (TSH), which is produced by the pituitary gland. These hormones regulate a host of metabolic processes throughout our body. When thyroid hormone levels fall, virtually every organ system slows down.

The symptoms of hypothyroidism often develop gradually. Fatigue, excessive sleepiness, dry skin, hair loss, puffiness of the face, constipation, sensitivity to cold, menstrual irregularities, impaired concentration and slowing of the pulse are all recognised features. Unfortunately, none of these symptoms is specific to hypothyroidism.

ism. They are often attributed to other conditions like ageing, stress, or nutritional deficiencies. Equally, once hypothyroidism is diagnosed, it is blamed for a host of subsequent symptoms, whether related or not.

No misconception is more widespread than the belief that hypothyroidism is a major cause of obesity. Patients are often relieved when they receive the diagnosis because they perceive that they have finally found an explanation for their weight gain. If you have mild or subclinical hypothyroidism (TSH 4.0, normal T3 and T4), you are unlikely to gain significant weight because of thyroid. Even untreated severe hypothyroidism usually accounts for no more than two to four kilograms of weight gain, much of it due to fluid retention rather than excess body fat. Correcting hypothyroidism is not, by itself, a weight-loss treatment.

Another area of widespread misinformation is diet. There is no scientifically proven “thyroid diet.” Patients are frequently advised to eliminate goitrogens, dairy products, cabbage, broccoli, cauliflower, and soy. Scientific evidence does not support these restrictions. When eaten as part of a normal diet in an iodine-sufficient population such as India, they have negligible clinical significance. Soy foods are also safe in moderation. Soy, calcium supplements, iron tablets, some antacids, and other supplements can interfere with absorption of the thyroxine pill, if taken along with it. The solution is

simple: Take the thyroid pill with water on an empty stomach, wait at least 30 to 60 minutes before breakfast or tea/coffee, and separate calcium and iron supplements by at least four hours.

Not everyone with mild hypothyroidism requires treatment. Of those who do, many hesitate to start treatment because the pills will be lifelong. The medication itself is not addictive. It is lifelong because the disease usually is. In most adults, hypothyroidism results from Hashimoto's thyroiditis, an autoimmune disorder in which the immune system gradually damages the thyroid gland. Thyroxine simply replaces what the body can no longer make. Hypothyroidism may also occur after thyroid surgery or radiation or because of medications. Rarely can a malfunctioning of the pituitary gland cause “secondary” hypothyroidism.

Patients often ask: “If my reports are normal now, why should I continue the medicine?” The answer is your thyroid hormone levels are normal because the medication is replacing the hormone your thyroid cannot produce. Stopping treatment will cause thyroid hormone abnormalities again. The medicine has controlled the condition; it has not cured it.

Fortunately, thyroxine remains one of the safest and most effective medications in modern medicine. It restores normal thyroid hormone levels and reverses almost all the manifestations of hypothyroidism. However, excessive doses may increase the risk of irregular heart rhythm, and accelerate bone loss, particularly in older adults. Regular monitoring helps ensure that the dose remains appropriate.

Another source of anxiety is the thyroid antibody report. Many patients are alarmed to discover that their thyroid peroxidase (TPO) antibody levels are very high despite taking treatment. These antibodies simply confirm autoimmune

(Hashimoto's disease). They do not require treatment in their own right. It is the TSH and thyroid hormone levels that guide management.

Who should be tested? Testing is strongly advised for new-born babies because some may be born with a defective or absent thyroid gland, and early treatment prevents permanent intellectual disability. Women planning pregnancy, or those who become pregnant, should have thyroid function assessed since even mild hypothyroidism may affect pregnancy outcomes and foetal brain development. Testing is also appropriate for individuals with autoimmune diseases, a strong family history of thyroid disorders, children with poor growth, women with infertility or menstrual disturbances, and people taking medications such as amiodone or lithium. Remember, though, to stop biotin containing supplements before getting tested as they can interfere with the lab measurement.

The internet is full of claims that hypothyroidism can be “cured” through special diets, supplements or alternative therapies. Unfortunately, there is no scientific evidence that any of these restores a permanently damaged thyroid gland. Likewise, despite recurring interest in T3-containing therapies, thyroxine (T4) alone remains the recommended treatment for the overwhelming majority of patients.

Hypothyroidism is one of the commonest endocrine disorders—and one of the easiest to treat. With an accurate diagnosis, the correct dose of thyroxine and periodic monitoring, most people can expect normal health, normal longevity and an excellent quality of life.

The greatest burden of hypothyroidism is often not the disease itself, but the myths that continue to surround it.

Amrish Mithal is chairman and head of Endocrinology and Diabetes at Max Healthcare. The views expressed are personal

Rocket in space to serve people on the ground

When Vikram-I lifted off from Sriharikota on July 18, it marked more than a technological triumph. Developed by an Indian startup, Skyroot Aerospace, it became India's first privately built orbital launch vehicle to successfully reach space. It is not just a story of a rocket, it is a story of public-private partnership and of what that rocket in space can do for people on the ground. India has long been recognised as a space power. The next chapter is about becoming a technology-enabled development power. Space technology, when combined with artificial intelligence (AI) and digital tech, holds the potential to transform some of the fundamental development-centric sectors such as agriculture, health care, climate resilience and disaster management. Vikram-I represents an important step towards that future. As an orbital launch vehicle that will carry small satellites (up to 350 kgs) into orbit—much like a truck carrying goods to their destination—it is central to satellites that serve important functions in the above-mentioned domains in a much faster and affordable manner. As costs fall, the affordability and use of space-derived information will rise.

Such satellites can monitor crop health, soil moisture, and weather patterns across millions of hectares in near-real-time. Combined with AI and digital advisory platforms, these data can generate location-specific recommendations for farmers on critical inputs such as

irrigation, fertiliser application, pest management, and harvesting. For over 100 million farm households of India, better information can mean higher incomes, lower risks and greater resilience.

The benefits extend beyond agriculture. Satellites continuously observe forests, rivers, glaciers, coastlines, groundwater, air quality and urban heat islands. This intelligence strengthens early warning systems for cyclones, floods, and heat waves, positioning authorities to act before disasters become humanitarian crises.

For health care, satellites become an enabler by connecting specialists in urban hospitals with remote villages where specialist care is scarce. During natural disasters, when terrestrial communication networks fail, satellite connectivity keeps emergency medical services operational.

Satellites also support disease surveillance by monitoring environmental conditions associated with vector-borne

diseases and improve the logistics of delivering medicines and vaccines to difficult-to-reach communities.

Another key vehicle like Vikram-I can lower the cost of access to space. This is especially important for a country like India where cost of innovation is one of the most critical factors for adoption and scale of innovation. Vikram-I thus holds the potential to accelerate innovation by startups, universities, state governments and businesses developing satellite-based solutions for agriculture, climate services, logistics, telecommunications, and public health.

India has repeatedly demonstrated that it can build world-class space technology at globally competitive costs. The challenge before us now is not simply to launch more rockets, but to ensure that every launch improves lives on the ground. The true measure of success for Vikram-I is not the altitude it reaches beyond the sky—but in the value it offers on the ground.

Purvi Mehta is a senior agricultural technologist. The views expressed are personal



Purvi Mehta

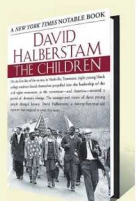
EDITOR'S PICK

HT's editors offer a book recommendation every Saturday, which provides history, context, and helps understand recent news events

CHANGE, COURTESY THE YOUTH

In one of the country's most visible student protests in the last decade, dissent and dissatisfaction have acquired new vocabularies to reach audiences through new media. But, anger at apathy (perceived or real) stays the same. Around the world, youth movements have been forcebeats of change.

This week, we recommend Pulling the Strings by David Halberstam's *The Children* (1998), a recounting of the Nashville protests of 1959-60 in the US. Black university students sought implementation of racial desegregation in lunch counters in the US's south. The *Children* captures the deep personal but politically entrenched stories of the protestors. Halberstam reflects on the movement's non-violent core, where protestors answered brutal crackdowns with a resolute rejection of violence. The *Children* remains a manual of how contesting ideologies coalesce within a larger ideal and how student leadership is refined in the most trying crucibles.



The Children
David Halberstam
1998

CJP-MINISTERS MEET

with another spokesperson Sarav Das, said they remained steadfast on the demand for Pradhan's resignation.

The government has asked for time till tomorrow afternoon on our demand for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. We hope the government will remove him soon. The government has expressed in-principle approval on the two demands of compensation (for families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide) and withdrawal of FIRs, legal cases on students," he said.

JP Nadda and Dr Jitendra Singh ji were apprised of increasing anger and discontent among people, which won't stop until Pradhan's resignation," he added.

The CJP memorandum also asked that security forces and the government apologise for the violence on July 20, and that the demands be accepted at the earliest. "If not, the movement would only grow bigger and spread across the country," it said.

The developments came a day after a dramatic midnight video appeal by PM Narendra Modi, who promised a new law to tackle examination question paper leaks and fast-track courts to deal with those accused of the crime. Minutes later, activist Sonam Wangchuk broke his 26-day-long hunger strike in the presence of Nadda and Singh at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram. Wangchuk had started fasting last month to support student protesters, before being forcibly removed from Jantar Mantar last week. But the CJP clarified that while it welcomed Wangchuk ending his strike, the str will continue.

On Friday, Modi thanked youngsters for the response to his video. In a fresh video message, he said: "Thank you friends. I had the opportunity to meet you late last night. I appreciate the way you responded to my video and your positive suggestions."

Over the past 48 hours, the government has kicked up several gears in its efforts to end the impasse with students, whose protest at Jantar Mantar continues to draw thousands of people pouring in from every corner of the Capital despite the closure of at least 15 metro stations for the past three days—one of the longest continuous history station closures in Delhi Metro's history—and the suspension of internet services for four days, also the longest in the Capital since the farmers' protest in 2021. Delhi Police has also briefly

detained over 150 people in south and southeast Delhi for carrying pepper spray or posters, triggering the ire of the agitators.

On Friday, the cabinet—chaired by the PM at the Parliament House complex—approved the draft bill to hand stricter punishments to those involved in paper leaks as compared to the existing law, people aware of developments said. In his video message, Modi had promised that "more-strict actions" against paper leaks will be discussed in the cabinet meeting. The bill will amend the 2024 Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, proposing a minimum punishment of five years in jail for individuals involved in paper leaks and/or a fine. The new bill may provide a jail term of up to 10 years and a maximum fine of ₹10 crore in case of organised paper leaks, the people cited above said.

The present law has provisions for three to five years' imprisonment for individuals, and five to 10 years' imprisonment and a minimum fine of ₹1 crore for those involved in the organised crime of cheating and paper leaks.

The existing law is aimed at curbing leaks, malpractices as well as organised malpractices in recruitment examinations and entrance tests.

To be sure, NEET was embroiled in controversy in 2024 and 2025—both coming after the 2024 law was passed.

The new bill is likely to come up in Parliament on Monday, as announced by Modi in his video message. But the Opposition has indicated that it will allow no discussion to take place in Parliament until Pradhan resigns. The first week of the monsoon session was washed out as a result.

In the evening, the government announced a large-scale culling in the National Testing Agency, which organises NEET and other major exams such as JEE Mains, CUET and UGC-NET. NTA terminated 47 officials—both permanent and contractual—and said legal and criminal actions will be taken against some, with people aware of developments describing the action as part of a complete overhaul of NTA, which has been mired in controversy over paper leaks. As part of its institutional overhaul, the NTA has begun recruiting specialist leadership in cybersecurity, digital forensics, assessment research and test-centre operations. It has advertised four General Manager positions on three-year contracts and, for

the first time, 16 Young Professional posts through UPSC's PRATIHA Setu portal in academic research, legal research, and finance.

The agency said the hiring is aimed at reducing dependence on contractual and outsourced staff, strengthening in-house expertise and implementing the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations. More recruitment across 10 functional verticals and fresh empanelment of subject experts and translators are planned. Since 2018, NTA has conducted more than 77 lakh registrations covering over 66 million registered candidates.

Born out of a controversial remark by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant earlier this year, the CJP first garnered millions of followers on social media before launching a sit-in protest on June 6 demanding the resignation of Pradhan over repeated question paper leaks. After days of tepid crowds, the movement was galvanised by the hunger strike and forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk last week.

Crowds swelled through the weekend and by Monday morning, columns of people—many of them students, first-time agitators and young professionals—had defied a steady drizzle and police barricading to join what became the largest street protest in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's third term. Over 100 protesters and 129 security personnel were injured when clashes between protesters and police led to injuries to five agitators and five police personnel. Visuals of the clashes—which broke out on Sansad Marg—showed hundreds of people on the streets, stone pelting and tear-gas shelling, and scores of police and paramilitary personnel in riot gear hitting out with batons.

Tensions have sporadically flared at the protest site, most dramatically on Wednesday night when clashes between protesters and police led to injuries to five agitators and five police personnel. Visuals of the clashes—which broke out on Sansad Marg—showed hundreds of people on the streets, stone pelting and tear-gas shelling, and scores of police and paramilitary personnel in riot gear hitting out with batons.

U.S. TARIFFS

Guatemala, Honduras, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Trinidad and Tobago, and the United Kingdom among those in the 10% bracket. Specific tariff arrangements have been put in place for the European Union, Taiwan, Japan, South Korea and Switzerland. US tariffs on India exports now fall into three broad categories, he said. Products covered by Section 232

of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962—steel, aluminium, copper, auto components and certain derivative products, accounting for around 8% of India's exports—will be subject to a 25% tariff, that the failure was unreasonable, and that it burdened or restricted US commerce—placing India in the 12.5% bracket at that stage. Representations by New Delhi in April, May and early July, followed by the July 13 ban, moved India into the lower group by the July 24 determination, people aware of the matter said. USTR said it had received over 1,600 written comments on the proposed action and held public hearings between July 7 and July 9 at which more than 100 witnesses testified.

Ajay Srivastava, founder of the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), described the outcome as a significant achievement given the United States is India's largest export destination. "India secured the lower 10% tariff, down from the 12.5% rate proposed in the USTR's draft, after introducing measures to prohibit imports made with forced labour," he said. "The USTR considered this a policy improvement, placing India in the lower-tariff category alongside 16 other economies."

The excess-capacity investigation, launched in the same month as the force-labour-one, covers 16 economies including India. Its outcome carries the potential to erode India's position against key export rivals—among them China, Vietnam, Indonesia, Malaysia, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh—persons aware of the matter said. Of India's neighbouring competitors, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh are not subject to the excess-capacity investigation. It produces duties on India but not on them, the party established by Thursday's action would invert.

Section 301, unlike Section 232, carries no rate ceiling and no fixed expiry, though it requires a formal investigation before duties can be imposed. The moves come against the backdrop of talks between New Delhi and Washington on the India-US bilateral trade agreement, which is still unfinalised.

Srivastava set out the shape of the tariff regime as it stands after Thursday's announcement (Friday, India time). US tariffs on Indian exports now fall into three broad categories, he said. Products covered by Section 232

of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962—steel, aluminium, copper, auto components and certain derivative products, accounting for around 8% of India's exports—will be subject to a 25% tariff, that the failure was unreasonable, and that it burdened or restricted US commerce—placing India in the 12.5% bracket at that stage. Representations by New Delhi in April, May and early July, followed by the July 13 ban, moved India into the lower group by the July 24 determination, people aware of the matter said. USTR said it had received over 1,600 written comments on the proposed action and held public hearings between July 7 and July 9 at which more than 100 witnesses testified.

The remaining roughly 70% of India's exports—including engineering goods, textiles and garments, chemicals, machinery, plastics, leather products, gems and jewellery, furniture, and most manufactured goods—will now attract the 10% Section 301 force-labour tariff in addition to the applicable MFN duty.

The Union commerce ministry did not respond to requests for a comment.

SEAFARER KILLED

uninterrupted flow of global commerce.

The incident occurred a day before a Russian attack that targeted the Guinea Bissau-flagged MV Golden Leo in the Black Sea and killed 10 people, including four Indian seafarers. The external ministry's statement did not specify who attacked the Omorfi, though the Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI) said on social media that the vessel was targeted by an Ukrainian drone. "India unequivocally condemns such attacks targeting commercial shipping and placing the lives of innocent civilian crew members at risk. It is a matter of serious concern that the freedom of navigation and international commerce is facing increasing threats," the statement said. The Indian embassy in Russia has reached out to relevant authorities and is making efforts to extend all possible assistance to the family of the Indian seafarer killed on the Omorfi.

Separately, LPG carrier Disha was hit by an unidentified missile on Friday. The Mozambique-flagged carrier, carrying 28 Indian nationals among its 30-member crew, was attacked near Iran. The missile struck the engine room, triggering a fire and causing a temporary loss of manoeuvrability.

A situation report prepared by the Directorate General of Maritime Administration said the engine room fire has been extinguished, the situation is under control, and the vessel has dropped anchor. All crew members are safe. Disha has a carry-

ing capacity of 78,488 cubic metres of liquefied gas.

The vessel's crew comprises 28 Indian nationals, one Sri Lankan master and one Vietnamese chief officer.

K D Rao of Watercraft Marine Services, which recruited all the crew members, said: "We got a message at 2.30 pm on Friday. There is no injury to the crew. The vessel is anchored. Owners are giving support and providing a tug. We have told the staff not to go in the engine room."

The Maritime Administration said six Indian vessels are currently in the Persian Gulf, west of the Strait of Hormuz, with 125 Indian seafarers onboard.

It said 14 vessels of Indian interest—comprising Indian-flagged and India-bound foreign-flagged ships—remain in the Persian Gulf (west of the Strait of Hormuz) and have been identified for evacuation. These include eight fertiliser carriers and six other vessels.

The report said 3,985 seafarers had been deployed by various shipping companies as of July 24. It added that incidents involving Indian-flagged vessels and 29 incidents involving foreign-flagged vessels carrying Indian crew have been reported.

The total number of Indian seafarers killed in the Russia-Ukraine conflict has gone up to five. More than half a dozen Indian seafarers have also been killed in Iranian and US attacks on merchant vessels in the Strait of Hormuz in recent weeks. The external affairs ministry has summoned senior Iranian, Russian and US diplomats to protest against these attacks.

Earlier in the day, external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaishankar rejected a suggestion from the Russian side that the Golden Leo was carrying arms when it was attacked. He said information from India's Directorate General of Maritime Administration showed the Golden Leo had loaded grain as cargo before its departure from Odessa port on July 19.

"We once again reiterate that commercial shipping and seafarers must not be targeted under any circumstances," he said, adding that external affairs minister S Jaishankar had made this position clear at the East Asia Summit and Asian Regional Forum meetings in the Philippines and also reiterated it with Russian foreign minister Sergey Lavrov.

SC seeks govt reply on NEET-UG in CBT mode

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday demanded clear answers from the Centre on whether it was keen to shift NEET-UG to a computer-based test (CBT), issues of data protection that may arise in that case, and implementation of earlier expert committee reports, as it pointed out that heightened measures such as deploying the Air Force this year can only be an ad-hoc measure and the effort should be to institutionalise the mechanism.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhya said, "We cannot let such a situation go on like this. We have to focus on institutionalisation. Ad-hocism is what has troubled us for so many years."

The court's observations came while hearing a batch of petitions

filed by Federation of All India Medical Association and United Doctors Front, among others, demanding replacing the National Testing Agency (NTA) with a statutory body that is accountable.

"What about the transition to CBT? In that case, it will no longer be physical transportation of question papers. How the data will be protected? A leak can occur if the data is not safe. This is most crucial. We need to know what is your thought about CBT, the security aspect linked to it, and who is to conduct it?" the bench asked.

Representing the Centre, Solicitor general Tushar Mehta said, "I have instructions to say that the government may go even beyond what the committee recommended. I will present a holistic view if the court grants me time. With children, there cannot be an adversarial approach," Mehta said.

The court posted the matter on August 3.

NEW FORMULA TO REDUCE TOLLS ON SOME HIGHWAYS

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NEW DELHI: Motorists using national highways with bridges, tunnels, flyovers and elevated stretches are set to pay less tolls under a new formula, with the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) on Friday directing all its field offices to begin processing toll notifications and revisions under the amended rules.

The move follows the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' July 1 amendment to the National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2008, which changes how user fees are calculated for highway stretches involving one or more independent bridges, tunnels, flyovers or elevated highways.

Under the revised rule, toll will be calculated by adding 10 times the length of such structures to the length of the remaining highway section, or five times the total length of the highway section, whichever is lower. Structures measuring 60 metres or less will not be treated separately for this purpose.

C'GARH TO TABLE UCC BILL IN NEXT ASSEMBLY SESSION

Ritesh Mishra
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RAIPUR: Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Friday said his government will introduce a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill in the upcoming winter session of the state Assembly.

Speaking to reporters at Raipur airport before leaving for Bengaluru, Sai said the BJP government was committed to implementing the UCC in the state.

"The committee's first meeting is being held today. We will get the UCC passed in the upcoming winter session of the Assembly," he said.

Earlier in the day, the five-member committee headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice (Retd.) Ranjana Prakash Desai held its first meeting at Mantralaya Mahanadi Bhavan in Nava Raipur Atal Nagar.

The committee was tasked with examining the legal framework for implementing a Uniform Civil Code in Chhattisgarh and making recommendations on issues such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption and other related matters.

EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

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FATIMA RIZVI | TRANSLATOR,
A TILT IN TIME: PARTITION &
PAKISTAN - A MID-CENTURY
MEMOIR BY QURATULAIN HYDER

Partition texts talk about trauma. I think Hyder took a conscious decision not to.

On the Books & Authors podcast
HT

INTERVIEW | LIVIA MANERA SAMBUI,
AUTHOR, IN SEARCH OF AMRIT KAUR

'Many didn't want me to discover what happened'

On rescuing the Rani of Mandi, who sold her jewels to save Jews in WW2 Paris, from becoming a footnote in history

Saurabh Sharma
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1 Your book engages with details that several authors wouldn't have considered exploring and stories that many deemed fictional. How important was it to you to document these details?

When I started working on this book I understood that, while details about the life of the Rani of Mandi were scarce, something else was evident: she had crossed the lives of many important and interesting characters — the Alsatian banker and philanthropist Albert Kahn, the groundbreaking artist Amrita Sher-Gil, the Russian guru-artist-entrepreneur Nicholas Roerich, and the hero of French resistance Jean Rosenthal, among others.

I found the way these lives developed and intersected with the tragic arc of hers extremely interesting. And I made a choice: my book would not be a straightforward biography, but the story of a quest — the quest for Amrit Kaur of Mandi, a princess whose history and other forces had obscured.

Through this quest, it would also be a cross-cultural portrait of an era: the era of the end of the British Empire, India's Partition, and the tragedy of World War 2 in France.

2 This quest for the Rani of Mandi came when you were grieving. How were you able to channel your energy towards telling Amrit Kaur's story?

They were certainly difficult years for me. I was grieving the loss of my brother. I separated from my husband. I started a new life in Paris. At some point, I did doubt that I would ever find the truth about the story of the Rani of Mandi selling her jewels to help Jewish friends leave France during German occupation, and paying for her courage with her life. Too many people didn't want me to discover what really happened. That sustained me was my commitment towards Bubbles, the Rani's daughter, who, in her 80s, wished to leave this world knowing why her mother abandoned her in 1933 and was never spoken about again in her family. Bringing closure to her and showing her, through some letters I found, that the Rani did want to go back to her daughter and son, but she stopped from doing so, was a worthy reward for me.

3 The Rani of Mandi could have been a celebrated figure for LGBTQIA+ people. A crucial part of her personal life was hidden. Would you consider that an act that hampered the advocacy for queer-feminist rights in India?

No. I wouldn't. It is a different era. We cannot judge it by today's values. She was bold in choosing to live more *uxorio* with the woman she loved — an American, and a Protestant. And she was equally bold in refusing to compromise. She paid a very high price for her choices. But she wasn't an activist, and she certainly wasn't open to sacrificing her privileges to the cause, as activists must do.

TELEVISION | HISTORY

Flashback to when DD ruled the airwaves

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Once upon a time, there was no television in India. This is a true story. When TV did arrive in the mid-1960s, the black-and-white transmission of regional programmes that focused on agriculture and education was limited to a few hours, and to few cities.

Colour TV was launched in India in 1982, and inform, educate and entertain the masses it did, but still within neat boundaries of transmission time and in a very prim format. *Doordarshan Diaries: The Golden Era of Television* by Sheila Chaman, a former anchor on Doordarshan

and a former Miss India, tells the story of TV's arrival in India complete with pictures, timelines and first-person accounts. The author describes how basic technology was often stretched and innovations made to make TV transmission available in the best possible formats to a larger number of citizens. She writes of times when telephones were unavailable and large chunks of text had to be memorised by those facing the camera. The book also provides insight into TV presentation skills, and traces how the sedate style of Doordarshan (DD) gave way to cable TV. There was no looking back after that shift. *Doordarshan Diaries* like reads like period fantasy to

those who've never known a life without screens. Multiple that effect manifold for those who have always known smartphones. This reviewer was seven when a Sony colour TV from Abu Dhabi was installed in their south Bangalore home. Naturally, the book brought back memories of TV serials and programmes that were of public functions being interrupted so the audience could watch the next episode of *Mahabharata* before returning to the programme and picking up where they had left off. At first, every-

one was united in sincerely savouring the limited fare offered by the single available channel. The regional film on Saturday evenings and the Hindi film on Sunday evenings were viewed more with devotion to routine than to cinema. Music programmes like *Chitrahaas*, and TV serials like *Hum Log*, *Buniyad*, *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi*, *Khandana*, *Udaan*, *Rajani*, *Nukkad* and *Mr Ya Mrs*, among others, had a devoted viewer-

ship across age groups. Mythological characters breezed into homes, and families bonded over the one prime-time TV serial that played every night. Equally gripping TV commercials modelled lifestyles and fashion aspirations, and school-fancy-dress competitions always had at least one *Lalaji* ('*Suri ki kharidari main hi samajhdari hai!*'). This was an era in which every household had to include an expert climber of walls and trees to adjust the rooftop TV antenna when video quality faltered.

Hindi and English newscasters were admired and respected for the grace and dignity they brought to the newscast. In that long-gone age, students were advised to watch the news to

strengthen language skills. No one knew then that, in a few decades, our collective minds would be blown by unlimited content from around the world, and that screens of every size would dominate our lives. *Doordarshan Diaries* captures all this.

It includes detailed back stories relating to historical events such as Emergency, the assassination of prime minister Indira Gandhi, and the anti-Sikh riots that followed in 1984. It also describes the author's personal journey in Indian television, beginning with the presentation of *Mirror of the World* in June 1976, for which Chaman received a cheque of Rs 75. The book weaves together history, culture, politics and

electronics, and the views of those at the helm during the DD era. A must-read for students of journalism and electronics, and for those who first encountered TV through DD, this is a great nostalgia trip.

Readers must keep in mind that the government broadcast-shaped and controlled news content as well, an aspect the author does touch upon. While the focus is Doordarshan, the heroes of this tale are really those who worked with it to lay the foundation of Indian television.

Charumathi Supraja is a poet and journalist based in Bengaluru

World IVF Day



Louise Brown, the world's first IVF baby, was born on July 25, 1978. Since that day 48 years ago, more than five million children have been born using in-vitro fertilisation. Above, a doublespread in the British newspaper Daily Mail announces the birth of Brown, the first "test tube baby", as children born with the help of Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) were initially called. Four years after her birth, her parents Lesley Brown and John Brown had another daughter, Natalie Brown, also through IVF. Today, both Louise, seen above right, and Natalie have children who were conceived without the help of ART.



GETTY IMAGES

A combustible history

Shaan Kashyap's *Who Owns the Past?* examines the relationship between historians, political power and the wider public in India

Ather Farooqui
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Few countries inhabit their past as turbulently as India. A medieval mosque, a school textbook, a TV serial, a translated paragraph, a campus lecture, even a dead emperor can become the occasion for a national argument. Professional historians claim interpretive authority over the past. Politicians seek legitimacy from it. Popular writers dramatise it. Religious movements sanctify it. Television simplifies it. Social media weaponises it. Somewhere amid all this, the public is left asking a deceptively simple question: Who owns the past? Shaan Kashyap's *Who Owns the Past? How Historians (Re)Wrote India's Past and Present, 1870-2020* enters precisely this crowded battlefield.

The book's narrative begins with late-19th-century textbook controversies involving figures such as Sir Syed Ahmad Khan and Raja Shiv Prasad. It moves through nationalist appropriations of the past, the Nehruvian attempt to construct a secular historical consensus, the rise of Marxist historiography, the Janata interlude, the communal anxieties of the 1980s, the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, and finally the ideological and media-driven conflicts of the Modi era.

But Kashyap's real subject is the unstable relationship between historians, political power and the wider public in India. Thus, what begins as a study of textbooks gradually becomes a chronicle of public intellectuals, academic institutions, newspaper interventions, TV debates, ideological struggles, conferences, censorship and cultural anxieties. The Indian republic unfolds through the biographies and public interventions of historians themselves: Irfan Habib, Romila Thapar, Bipan Chandra, RS Sharma, and others who were not merely writing history but attempting, often unsuccessfully, to shape the moral and political imagination of the republic. This is what gives the book its originality.

A particularly fascinating strand running through the

book concerns the making of official history after Independence. Kashyap carefully revisits the celebrated disagreement between RC Majumdar and Tara Chand over the official history of the freedom struggle. It is among the most revealing sections because it captures the birth of postcolonial state-sponsored history writing. The author demonstrates how historians became increasingly integrated into the architecture of the postcolonial state itself. NCERT, the Indian History Congress, university departments, and official commissions together produced what the book describes as a model of history-writing dedicated to national integration.

The ambition was admirable. The exclusions, however, remained unresolved. Particularly memorable are the pages dealing with Emergencies. Kashyap documents the uneasy relationship between historians and authoritarian power during the 1970s. The arrival of the book's title is a quiet but devastating. Historians who had long positioned themselves as guardians of democratic rationality often found themselves intellectually disoriented when confronted with authoritarianism emerging from within the secular state they broadly supported.

One of the book's most revealing episodes captures this with unusual clarity. In 1981, at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU), the eminent historian Irfan Habib found himself denounced as a "Russian agent" and a "Communist dog" amid a bitter campus confrontation. Kashyap reconstructs the affair as a revealing moment in the history of modern India, when the historian became a public combatant, ideological symbol and political target. That tension animates the entire book.

Kashyap moves from the Irfan Habib controversy at AMU to textbook agitations in Maharashtra, communal anxieties, the Shah Bano debate, the Salman Rushdie affair, caste mobilisation, and the growing influence of mythological television. What emerges is a portrait of India in transition. The work reaches its intellectual height in the chapters devoted to the turbulent years preceding the demolition of the Babri Masjid. Particularly noteworthy is the chapter titled *Ram, Allah and the Illegitimacy of History*. Here Kashyap examines the process by which history itself became politically illegitimate in large sections of

public life. Historians insisted upon evidence, method and complexity. Political movements increasingly relied upon memory, grievance, faith and civilisational sentiment. The conflict was no longer merely ideological. It concerned fundamentally different conceptions of truth.

Kashyap is especially perceptive in analysing the limitations of India's secular intelligentsia during this period. Conferences multiplied. Essays were written. Resolutions were passed. Yet mass politics moved elsewhere, into televised religiosity, symbolic grievance and populist mobilisation. The arrival of serials such as *Ramayana* transformed the emotional scale of persuasion. Academic rebuttals could not compete with mythology entering millions of homes every Sunday morning. The book also carefully documents the selective silencing of intellectual life during the Shah Bano controversy and the Rushdie affair. Kashyap shows how sections of the liberal intelligentsia often struggled to confront minority conservatism with the same confidence they reserved for majoritarian politics. Sections such as these give the book an unusual moral depth because the author refuses the temptations of retrospective heroism. He examines not only what historians said but also what they chose not to say.

This balance constitutes one of the book's greatest strengths. Kashyap neither romanticises historians nor demonises them. He takes them seriously enough to criticise them honestly. The result is a work that explains why history in India repeatedly becomes combustible and why the past here is never inert. At a moment when every ideological camp seeks possession of the past, *Who Owns the Past?* returns us to a more difficult proposition: history is not an inheritance to be owned, nor a weapon to be wielded, but an argument that must be continually renewed. Evidence may not always prevail, and historians may not always persuade, but without the discipline of historical inquiry, a society eventually becomes captive to memory, sentiment and power alone.

Kashyap's achievement lies in compelling us to confront this. That is a rare accomplishment than advocacy and a more enduring one than polemic.

Ather Farooqui holds a PhD from Jawaharlal Nehru University and is general secretary of Anjuman Taraqqi Urdu (Hind), New Delhi

HT PICKS | NEW READS

FOR A BETTER HANDLE ON LIFE

Drawing on unique expertise gained over his 25 years as an FBI counterintelligence officer, Joe Navarro shows how to use simple body-language tools to transform relationships through everyday interactions, both personal and professional.

With the help of Navarro's easy-to-grasp insight and practical advice, one can expect to master the art of the first impression, learn how to build trust and rapport with someone new, handle workplace negotiations with greater ease, defuse tension and conflict, prepare better for a first date, and foster positive relationships.

Navarro's body-language insight and tools aim to give the individual a better handle on life by making them capable of building more meaningful friendships and relationships.

Mastering Connections
Joe Navarro
247pp, ₹699, HarperCollins

EXPLORING HOMELAND, EXILE AND IDENTITY

The protagonist of Herta Müller's *Traveling on One Leg* is Irene, a fragile woman, born to a German family in Romania, who has recently emigrated from Romania to Germany. The novel focuses on her relationship with three men: Franz, whom she met in Romania and who is unwilling to respond to her love for him; Stefan, a friend of Franz; and Thomas, a bookseller in perpetual crisis about his identity.

As a recent emigrant and unassimilated Romanian in Germany, Irene feels neither longing for Romania nor any comfort in her newly adopted home. Politically and socially isolated, she moves within the emotional orbit of these three men, while at the same time moving between West Berlin, Marburg, and Frankfurt, taking a dissonant journey within strange yet familiar territory.

Characterised by a sense of isolation, *Traveling on One Leg* is a poignant exploration of exile, homeland and identity.

Traveling on One Leg
Herta Müller, Translated by Valentina Glajar and André Leferve
154pp, ₹399, Aleph

A PROFOUND MEDITATION ON CHILDHOOD

Nobel Prize-winning poet Louise Glück's only published piece of fiction, *Marigold and Rose* is a novella about the eponymous twins' first year in the world. In deceptively simple prose, Glück portrays the prelinguistic inner lives of Marigold, who is "the thinking one", and Rose, who is "everything else".

Even in infancy, Marigold longs for adulthood with its "vast cargo of words". She has started writing a book in her mind. Rose is sociable, curious and self-assured. In one year, the twins go from being "tadpoles" to "actual miniature people". By and by, the safety of infancy disappears, and they must grapple with the "chaos and imprecision" of the world of grownups. Marigold and Rose is a profound meditation on childhood, language and individuality.

Marigold and Rose
Louise Glück
63pp, ₹399, Aleph

ontheweb

READ: Written with great affection for the charming town in the Kumaon Hills, Janhavi Prasad's *Nainital: Through Memory* Stories & History is packed with detail. It also recalls an idyllic childhood foraging for wild berries, breathing unpolluted air, and drinking water that flowed from the upper reaches of the Deopata hills.

Scan the QR code to read the review by Chintan Girish Modi



Sheila Chaman (far right) on her talk show, *Live Wire*. HTAROWES

electronics, and the views of those at the helm during the DD era. A must-read for students of journalism and electronics, and for those who first encountered TV through DD, this is a great nostalgia trip.

RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE

HT brunch

You, me and cupid.exe

Can a bot set you up? As AI screens profiles, gives flirting tips and sets up dates, see where matchmaking is headed

Christalle Fernandes

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For the past few months, 23-year-old Urvasi Gormat has been chatting with a new friend. They discuss the kind of boys Gormat likes, what makes her heart flutter, her favourite singers, and what concerns she's planning to attend. The friend has been trying to set her up with a few guys. "She really gets me," says Gormat, a content strategist and marketer in Bengaluru. "She knows exactly the things I like in a person. It's fun to talk and even lowkey rant to her."

Gormat's "friend", though, isn't human. It's Wave, an AI companion built by the dating app Wavelength, which launched in April this year. Wavelength, like other bot-based dating apps, is hoping to serve as a digital version of the viral matchmaker Sima Taparia. "Wave asks me more questions than Sima does," Gormat says. Thus far, Wave has suggested over 30 profiles to her. "I've not found a person yet."

It's a rough time to want to date. Around the world, more young people are choosing to remain single. In news articles, the term 'lingo' is being expanded to include 'Swipe fatigue' (burnout from constantly rejecting profiles) and 'Microcheating' (when a partner crosses boundaries in ways that add up to a betrayal). Dating apps are struggling to retain paid customers. Tinder, Bumble and Hinge are moving to AI-based matchmaking. Bots, for the most part, are objective, tireless and easy to retain. Could they set singles up with someone who matches their freak?

Wires crossed
Dating apps were already using some form of back-end AI to sort profiles, study swiping behaviour and suggest partners based on customers' preferences. "A decade ago, the goal was to expand your options beyond your circle of friends and acquaintances," says Karima Ben Abdelmalek, the CEO and president of dating service, Happn. "Now, people don't want a buffet of options. They want to choose from three or four people they can see themselves connecting with."

Apps are hoping AI can also pitch in with the initial flirting and vibe-check. On most new apps, there are digital matchmakers, dating coaches, assistants or avatars to take over the pesky task of assessing a potential partner. Bumble's assistant is called Bee. Overtime, a new app run by the Hinge founder, will launch later this year. On Tinder, Chemistry and Learning Mode are operational in Australia and New Zealand.

UK's Romeo & Juliet, which launches in India soon aims to shortlist partners for clients.

Here's how the free-for-no service works: Clients have a five-minute conversation with the AI Juliet, who asks them how they spent their weekend, how they'd resolve conflict in a relationship, what their love languages are, and what kind of support they'd want from a partner after a difficult day. Clients then list their non-negotiables: Political opinions, educational levels expected from a partner. Then, Romeo, the second AI, looks through the system and matches them to someone that seems compatible.

Wavelength and Knot.Dating work in similar ways. On Fluter, it's possible to tighten filters: Bengali girl, 5'5, loves to travel, has long hair. It even lets an AI avatar of one client chat with AI avatars of potential partners endlessly, saving humans the effort of rejecting and being rejected. "Most people need a third person, a go-between, to introduce them and help them build their relationship in the first few months," says Vinit Sarode, 27, Wavelength's co-founder and COO. He's hoping that AI is that connector.

Jasveer Singh, co-founder of Knot.Dating, has added detailed questions for AIs to ask clients, down to Netflix faves, how they like to spend time on a weekend, and the last book they read. Subscription fees start at \$50/month. "It's for people looking for serious relationships that last," says Singh. The 15-minute AI call also covers hypothetical questions: How would you spend your days if you were alone on a deserted island? How would you react when your boss disagrees with you? "We don't just look at the information; we pay attention to your tone, how fast or slow you speak, to get a fuller picture of who you are as a person."

Rejection rate

It works, in theory. Even Sima Aunty, well-meaning parents, and besties can get it wrong when they try to set two people up. Because humans are really good at presenting the best version of themselves—on a date, to a fiancée's family, to a spot. AI isn't primed to spot psychoses, bigotry, if someone is violent or secretly nating. Bengaluru-based match-

Vasudha Khatuwalla (below) founded Romeo & Juliet, an AI-based dating app. Matchmaker Radhika Moha (bottom) says compatibility is built on trust and respect.

ILLUSTRATIONS CREATED USING CHATGPT

maker Radhika Moha sweeps these AI questions away. What a relationship boils down to, she believes, is respect and trust, which algorithms can't predict. "Nobody has ever come up to me and said, 'On an ideal Sunday in my future life, I want to be with a six-foot-tall guy with blue eyes'."

Moha says, "What they want is someone who'll show up for plans without flaking, whose words match their actions, whom they can count on to be there for them."

Kaushik Banerjee, co-founder and CEO of Fluter, admits that even with AI shortlisting potential partners, clients still have to do the talking, flirting and dating on their own. Bots are trained to connect commonalities—hikers match with hikers, extroverts match with social butterflies. So, the connections they suggest tend to be the safest ones.

Safe bets work well when you're hiring for a job. But love? Love is complicated. AI could never predict that Vicky Kaushal or Katrina Kaif could have a thing. Or why Lana Del Rey sings, "When you know you know."

"The recommendations I get ticks everything on my list," says Gormat. "But no one really falls in love with lists, do they?" Besides, as most longtime singles know, every app draws from the same pool of actual humans. Bots can do all the filtering they can, but if shirts like Aayan from Delhi has profiles on multiple platforms, they can't invent a whole other person.

Holding hands

One issue, at least, seems to be somewhat solved. Wavelength says it has 32% women users and 65% men. Knot.Dating has a user base of 60% women and 40% men. The gender gap may be closing. Wavelength and Fluter's AI matchmakers also double as dating coaches, encouraging users to give a date another shot or suggest ways to keep the conversation going. "It's particularly useful for users from smaller towns, who have not been taught how to interact in a romantic setting," says Banerjee. Being an interesting person, however, is all on you. Even with prompts, people's conversations are so dry," says Anshu Dhar, a 36-year-old entrepreneur from Bengaluru who has tried both Wavelength and Knot.Dating and hasn't gone on any dates yet. "The larger issue is that people don't want to put in the effort to date."

Apps are trying to fix that, too. Happn's feature, Perfect Date, holds events and mixers for singles. Wavelength is planning to roll out a paid feature that curates dates. Users just have to show up and have a good time. So, AI or no AI, singles are just going to have to make sure they're messy date scene themselves. Gormat is still hoping she'll bump into her person in the real world, "like an old-school meet-cute at a museum or a karaoke session." It's the best-case scenario. Because who wants to thank a bot during someone's wedding toast?

column { rude food }

Pind to our homepage

Indian cuisine often means generic Punjabi fare. But chefs in the US, UK and India are finally giving Punjabi food delicious new respect



VIR SANGHVI

Punjabi food is having a moment. It has travelled from Pandhara Road and the Moti Mahal-type restaurants to find new fame in the world's capitals.

In London, Ambassadors Clubhouse, which serves Punjabi food, is packing them in and its new New York outpost is so successful that the New York Times headlined its review last week by noting that "It's one of the hardest reservations in New York." Ligaya Mishan, its reviewer (who really knows her Indian food), said about the cuisine that "If Ambassadors Clubhouse is not quite a revelation, it's in part because of this bounty, but also because Punjabi food was the gateway to Indian cuisine for many New Yorkers."

The gateway thing may be the problem for North-Indian food everywhere. Because nearly everyone is familiar with say, Tandoori Chicken and Black Dal, it is hard to surprise people with Punjabi restaurant food.

The JKS group, run by the three Sethi siblings (Punjabis who grew up in England) serve traditional Indian food, but do it better. Their flagship restaurant, Gymkhana, in London won two Michelin stars. And Ambassadors Clubhouse (one Michelin star) is determinedly Punjabi. It's the same approach that Vikas Khanna, who proudly advertises his Punjabiness, took with Bungalow, his New York restaurant, which won three stars from the New York Times.

But around a decade ago, people were so tired of eating the same Punjabi food at every place that most North-Indian restaurants came to be seen as Punjabi-owned operations, in which the entire menu was based around three basic curries.

But Punjabi food is making a comeback. This time it's the Punjabi food, not the three-curry formula that's finding favour.

Two decades ago, the late great Jiggs Kalra opened Punjabi Grill, serving authentic Punjabi food made to traditional recipes he had gathered. Jiggs partnered with Lite Bite Foods, but his son Zorawar sold his shares



to Lite Bite and went off to start an emment of his own: Masala Library. Farzi Cafe etc. But now, there are around 60 Punjabi Grills around the country, all still using Jiggs's original recipes.

Rohit Aggarwal, who founded Lite Bite with Amit Burman, recently retired from the group. Looking back, he attributes Punjabi Grill's success to its ability to fill a gap in the market. People always liked Punjabi food, he says, they were just fed up of what many restaurants were doing to it.

Rajan Sethi tells a similar story. He wanted to go back to the food of his parents who were born in undivided Punjab. His successful Ikk Panjab restaurants try and recreate the food his parents would have eaten: Koksapora Aata Chicken, Amritsari Aloo Vadiyan and Tarn-Tarn Di Jalebi Raddi. Sethi has four Ikk Panjab restaurants in Delhi, but the real test came when he opened a 120-seat restaurant in Chandigarh recently. To his relief, it has been a huge success.

What all of these restaurants have in common is one principle: Stop treating Punjabi food as a generic North-Indian cuisine and accord it the respect we would give to a great regional cuisine.

Nobody does that better than Aminder Sandhu. I first ate her Punjabi food at Masala Bay at the Taj Lands End, at Arthi in Mumbai, where every dish was cooked on an open fire, and then at Bawri also in Mumbai. She was already on her way to becoming one of India's top chefs when she opened

Kikili in Delhi's Connaught Place. I went there with my Punjabi wife, who normally refuses to eat at Punjabi restaurants ("No discerning Punjabi eats this stuff") and much to my surprise, she loved it.

What makes Kikili so good? Well, it's partly what you would expect: The food is authentic. But mostly it's because Sandhu is such a good chef. She comes from a Sikh family that has lived in Assam for three generations. For her family, food and the recipes that were handed down from mother to daughter became a way of asserting their Punjabiness in faraway Assam and staying in touch with their roots.

Perhaps the success of places like Ambassadors Clubhouse abroad, the global popularity of Vikas Khanna and the willingness of newer Indian restaurants and chefs to make real Punjabi food will change the way we look at the state and its cuisine.

Tandoori Chicken is a great invention. But it's an invention nevertheless. May be it's time for us to eat what Punjabis have eaten at home for generations.

The views expressed by the columnist are personal

This week we're...



Frozen with rage
The Book of Enoch, taken seriously only by the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, has gone viral because it mentions a cold prison for fallen angels at the end of the Earth. Randos assume this must be Antarctica. Theories are exploding on podcasts and TikTok. Antarctica is fragile enough without the conspiracy theories. Leave it alone. Also, who's got all this free time to take up such wild stories?

Staying in
Bad news for nightclubs everywhere. Not only are Gen Zs not drinking, not spending, not boogieing. They're afraid of discos. Not the sex-drugs-

rock'n'roll part. They're paranoid that they'll end up in someone else's frame, looking plastered, and going viral. Hug your Gen Z friends, folks. They're preparing for their Netflix documentary.

Starry eyed
Guess who's having a great year (and was not even in The Odyssey)? Anya Taylor-Joy. Her show, Lucky, is dominating Apple TV charts. The Gorge, last year's Valentine's Day release, has crossed 500 days on the streamer's leaderboard. She was Princess Peach in The Super Mario Galaxy Movie and

will play Alia Ardeides in Dune: Part Three. Everyone who made fun of her wide-set eyes... she's too busy to give you a hard stare.

Checking out
That dream all readers have, of owning a bookstore in London and just reading all day? Jessica Fox's The Open Book in Scotland lets you rent a small apartment and run the second-hand bookstore below. Charming. But dealing with fussy customers and learning how much money—and effort—

goes into retail will soon kill the vibe. Stay in the fantasy section, people!

Blushing pink
Until last week, Ernesto Casillas was a nobody. But after he worked on Zendaya's makeup for The Odyssey premiere in NYC, he's everyone's new hero. Casillas says her look was "sunkissed, like she'd flown too close to the sun." That means a red blush on the cheeks and nose. No liner. No mascara. Every rule broken. Is this how we're doing our faces now? So epic!

WANT TO READ MORE?

Check out the second page of HT Brunch in the epaper. And dive into stories about life, love, good times and good vibes in the digital magazine, out every Saturday. We're also on hindustantimes.com/lifestyle/brunch, and the HT app (it's free!)



READ the e-mag here!





Mohammed Shahabuddin AN

BANGLADESH'S
PRESIDENT, A
CLOSE ALLY OF
HASINA, RESIGNS

DHAKA: Bangladesh's President Mohammed Shahabuddin, appointed during the rule of ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned on Friday half-way through his term following years of political turbulence in the South Asian country.

A new government headed by Tarique Rahman, the son of former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia and Hasina's arch-rival, came to power with a landslide victory in February after 18 months of interim rule under Nobel Peace Prize laureate Muhammad Yunus. Hasina stepped down and fled to India in August 2024 following an anti-government movement that ended her 15-year rule.

Hasina fiercely criticised the interim administration led by Yunus.

Shahabuddin submitted his resignation on Friday to Parliament Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmad, citing medical reasons. The resignation letter was seen by The Associated Press. The speaker told a news briefing later on Friday that he accepted the resignation.

But local media reported that Shahabuddin had to resign under pressure from the current government as he allegedly talked to Hasina by phone when he visited London for medical treatment in May.

Following her ouster, he faced strong opposition from a student group that led the uprising against Hasina. The protesters branded him a collaborator of Hasina and took to the streets demanding his resignation and arrest.

ASSOCIATED PRESS

‘Major punishment’: US strikes targets across Iran

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

DUBAI: US missiles struck targets across Iran on Friday after President Donald Trump vowed “major military punishment” for Tehran and its Houthi allies in Yemen for extending the Middle East war to a second major shipping chokepoint, the mouth of the Red Sea.

Two weeks after the collapse of an interim truce meant to end the war, the Iranian armed forces responded by firing at US bases in neighbouring Arab countries and warning people there that they may strike non-military buildings used by US personnel.

The Houthis, who control northern and western Yemen, have announced a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia, which has diverted millions of barrels of oil each day by pipeline to the Red Sea to skirt Iran's near-total blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Brent crude at \$96

The Houthi fighters struck two Saudi tankers on Thursday in the Red Sea's Bab el-Mandeb strait, boosting oil prices 7% to \$100 per barrel for the first time since May. However, by around 1600 GMT on Friday, Brent futures were down more than \$4 to a little over \$96.

Meanwhile, the Houthi attacks forced several other tankers to turn around and head north through the Suez Canal, potentially using a much longer route to reach Asia by sailing around Africa.

Still, half of the 18 ships exiting Bab el-Mandeb on Thursday were carrying crude oil, including two Chinese tankers. The number of tankers crossing through the Strait of Hormuz fell to just one on Thursday, the lowest since May 7.

The Iranian and Omani foreign ministers discussed security developments and navigation in the Strait of Hormuz that runs between the two countries in a



Smoke rises after explosions were heard and air defences activated near the airport in Erbil, Iraq, on Friday. AFP

Pakistan, Iran explore path towards new talks with US

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan is exploring a path towards a resumption of stalled US-Iran talks over ending their nearly five-month-old war, three Pakistani sources said, following a push initiated by China.

Exploratory discussions took place during a visit by Iran's Interior Minister Eskandar Moniri to Islamabad this week — his second

within the last 10 days, the sources said. Moniri, who is considered close to Iran's Revolutionary Guard Corps, met with Pakistani government leaders and army chief Asim Munir this week, according to Pakistani government statements. All three sources cautioned that the obstacles to any talks with the US remain high.

REUTERS

phone call, a statement on Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi's Telegram channel said.

US forces threatened

Iranian media cited the head of Iran's top joint military command as saying Iran would kill a member of the US forces for every Iranian killed. The war has led to the deaths of 18 US service members. The Pentagon

said on Monday that 100 service members had been injured since July 7 and 96% have returned to duty.

The Iranian army said it had attacked US military equipment depots at Al-Adiri, officially named Camp Buehring, in northern Kuwait, and the positions of US troops at Camp Arifjan and at Camp Doha, near Kuwait City. In the early even-

FROZEN IRANIAN ASSETS WILL PAY FOR DAMAGE TO SHIPPING: TRUMP

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said on Thursday that the US would begin using frozen Iranian assets to pay for ships and cargo damaged by strikes in and around the Gulf. “Please let this statement serve to represent, until further notice, that from this point forth, any and all damages done to ships, cargo, or anything related thereto, will be paid for by Iranian Money that the United States has in its possession, and controls,” Trump said on his social media platform Truth social.

ing, Kuwait said its air defences were intercepting “hostile” targets launched from Iran.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said they had significantly damaged a surveillance tower used by the US Fifth Fleet in Bahrain. They also said they had attacked a US barracks and fighter jets in Jordan, and a US barracks and spy balloon as well as Patriot air defences in Erbil in Iraq's Kurdish region, according to the semi-official Tasnim news agency.

Trump warns China, Russia US President Donald Trump said on Friday that he does not believe China or Russia are “participating” in the ongoing Iran conflict, but warned that if they did get involved “it would be very bad for them”.

“President Xi [Jinping], at our recent meeting in Beijing, China, told me that he would not, under any circumstances, give or sell Weapons to the Islamic Republic of Iran — And that statement included Chinese Companies,” he wrote on Truth Social.

Canada-US drug trafficking: 13 Indian-origin men arrested

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
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TORONTO: At least 13 suspects of Indian origin have been arrested as part of a cross-border investigation involving Canadian and American law enforcement, leading to the seizure of nearly 1.7 tonnes of illegal drugs with an estimated street value of approximately CAD\$39 million (\$98.7 million).

In its announcement of the outcome of investigation, dubbed Project Bay, Canada's Ontario Provincial Police (OPP) said that the drugs seized included suspected cocaine (973kg), methamphetamine (660kg) and opium “marking one of the most significant drug seizures in a single investigation in Ontario”.

Overall, 21 suspects are fac-



Firearms seized during the Project Bay investigation.

ing 102 charges in connection with the investigation. They include Gagandeep Thindal, 27, Simranjit Singh, 32, Jatinderpal Singh, 39, Jasvinder Sohi, 55, Tejwinder Sandhu, 29, Tarninder Singh, 19, Gundeep Tariwal, 32, Mehakpreet Singh, 24, and Karandeep Singh, 27, all residents of Brampton in the Greater Toronto Area, as well as Kan-

warpal Kular, 32, of LaSalle, Harjinder Sandhu, 33, of Kitchener, Haninderpal Grewal, 34, of Barrie, and Avtar Sahota, 54, of Shelburne. Project Bay's genesis came in January last year when Windsor Police Service initiated a drug-trafficking investigation, which was joined by the Canadian Border Services Agency a month later.

As the scope and complexity of the investigation expanded, OPP was also engaged. As the case progressed, US agencies, including Homeland Security Investigations and the Drug Enforcement Administration, assisted with international aspects of the investigation, while the Toronto Police Service and Peel Regional Police provided operational and investigative support.

AF | PAKISTAN | IN KHYBER PAKHTUNKHWA

12 soldiers among 15 dead in suicide attack

Reuters & AFP

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DERA ISMAIL KHAN: Islamist militants rammed an explosive-laden vehicle into a Pakistani security checkpoint, killing 15 people, including 12 soldiers, in northwest Pakistan, the military said on Friday, adding that 12 militants had been killed in retaliation.

“Fifteen brave sons of soil including 12 military, two policemen and a government official rendered the ultimate sacrifice and embraced Shahadat (martyrdom),” the military's media wing said in a statement on the attack in the border province of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP).

The attack on the post jointly manned by the military and police happened overnight between Thursday and Friday in the Tank district near the Afghan border, an area that has

long served as home to Islamist militants. Militancy has risen sharply in the northwest Pakistan in recent months.

The army engaged the militants, who after failing to breach the security of the checkpoint drove the explosive-laden vehicle into its outer wall, the military's statement said. Local Taliban militants, also known as Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan, claimed responsibility for the attack, saying four suicide bombers took part in it, according to a statement.

The Taliban have been waging a war against the Pakistani state since 2007 in an attempt to overthrow the government and replace it with their own brand of strict Islamic governance.

Islamabad says the militants use safe havens in Afghanistan to train and plan attacks in Pakistan, a charge Kabul denies. Afghanistan says the militancy is Pakistan's domestic problem.



Ukraine-Russia war: 21 killed in strikes

KYIV: At least 21 people were killed on Friday in Russian and Ukrainian long-range strikes. Russian strikes killed 10 people near Kyiv and 5 in the frontline city of Sloviansk while Ukrainian drones killed 6 people at a factory in Russia's Kirov city, hundreds of kilometres east of Moscow.

AFP

ICC chief prosecutor removed from post

THE HAGUE: Member states of International Criminal Court (ICC) on Friday voted to dismiss Karim Khan as chief prosecutor following allegations of sexual misconduct, two diplomatic sources said. At least 82 of ICC's 125 member states voted in favour of the prosecutor's removal.

REUTERS

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West Asia flare-up jolts retail, HNIs' F&O bets

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MUMBAI: Retail investors, including high-net-worth individuals, have suffered significant losses this week as the benchmark Nifty 50 slipped below the 24,000 level, which had served as a strong support for weeks. Having correctly anticipated the initial correction, they turned bullish again just as renewed tensions in West Asia sparked a broader sell-off, leaving their index call bets deep in the red.

These investors, who tend to be net buyers of Nifty 50 and Nifty Bank call options and net sellers of puts, apart from being bullish on stocks, actually played a negative card for this Tuesday's weekly Nifty expiry.

After remaining net long until last Thursday, retail investors turned net sellers of index calls on Friday and Monday, expecting the Nifty to correct. It did, allowing them to pocket gains. A call seller, or bear, gains when the underlying index or stock falls or remains flat. A put seller, or bull, gains when the opposite happens. Call buyers are bullish, while put buyers are bearish.



Retail investors turned net sellers of index calls on Friday and Monday after remaining net long until last Thursday.

However, they have turned net bullish on index options again since Tuesday, expecting the 24,000 support level to hold despite the resumption of fighting in West Asia, weeks after a fragile ceasefire signed by the US and Iran on 17 June came apart. But the fall in the markets, with the 24,000 call expiring on 28 July (coming Tuesday), since they again became buyers, has burnt their fingers.

The 24,000 call has fallen almost 80% to ₹75 per share—65 shares make one contract—on

Thursday, down from ₹343 on Monday. The cohorts turned long index calls on 146,775 contracts on Tuesday, showed data from the National Stock Exchange.

This after turning net short index calls by 21,750 contracts on Friday and 104,565 on Monday. The sellers on index calls tend to be foreign portfolio investors, according to NSE data.

"The steep fall in calls has trapped the buyers, thanks to a surge in geopolitical tensions," said Kruti Shah, quant analyst at

Equirus Securities.

The tensions, which began building since 10 July, saw Brent crude surge 3% to \$100.69 a barrel since that date through Thursday, according to investings.com. For India, world's third-largest importer of crude, the rise in oil prices since the start of the war in February threatens its macroeconomic outlook by impacting the balance of payments, making equities more vulnerable. A continuation of hostilities could further disrupt global oil supplies, with Iran-backed Houthi expanding the conflict into the Red Sea and threatening Saudi oil shipments. Already 10% of the daily global oil supply of 104 million barrels has been disrupted due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, according to S.K. Joshi, director at Khambhati Securities.

Resumption of hostilities will impact our markets, which have held up pretty well around 24,000 so far," said Ketan Marwadi, managing director, Marwadi Shares and Finance Ltd. The benchmark Nifty 50 fell nearly 2% from 24,334.5 last Friday through 23,869.6 on Thursday. The Nifty slipped by another 0.4% to 23,767.45 on Friday.

Private sector growth slows to 4-yr low in July

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NEW DELHI: India's private sector activity expanded at its slowest pace in more than four years in July as a sharp loss of momentum in services outweighed an improvement in manufacturing output, while inflationary pressures intensified, according to HSBC Flash Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) data released by S&P Global on Friday.

The HSBC Flash India Composite PMI Output Index fell to 54.3 in July from 57.1 in June. While the reading remained above the 50 mark separating expansion from contraction, it is the lowest since February 2022 (when it was 53.5) and the same as the reading in March 2022. Firms attributed the slowdown to increasingly challenging market conditions, competitive pressures, order cancellations, fewer client enquiries and shortages of key raw materials.

The moderation was concentrated in services. The HSBC Flash India Services PMI Business Activity Index fell to 53.1 in July from 57.4 in June, marking the weakest pace of expansion in 53 months. Manufacturing trends were more mixed. The HSBC Flash India Manufacturing Index, which measures factory production, rose to 57.0 from



The moderation was led by the services sector.

56.3 as production growth accelerated. However, the headline HSBC Flash India Manufacturing PMI, which measures overall factory conditions based on new orders, output, employment, suppliers' delivery times and stocks of purchases, slipped to 53.9 from 54.2, signalling a below-trend improvement in overall factory conditions. Flash data are calculated from around 80-90% of total survey responses and are intended to provide an early indication of the final readings.

Growth in new business also slowed sharply. Although private sector orders continued to rise, the pace of expansion was the weakest in close to four-and-a-half years and moderate by historical standards. The slowdown was driven by services, where new business grew at its weakest pace since February

2022. Manufacturing, by contrast, recovered some of the momentum it had lost previously.

"Renewed tensions in the Middle East have once again resulted in firms building buffers to manage the uncertainties around the longevity of the supply-side shock. Finished goods and input inventories increased alongside a pick-up in purchasing volumes," said Pranjal Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC.

Even though the July data shows weaker expansion overall, both sectors reported growth in export orders. Growth in exports accelerated more in the manufacturing sector as the seasonally adjusted index for new export orders rose by nearly four points. At the composite level, the latest update in international sales was the most pronounced since March.

Employment rose for the seventh consecutive month in July. The pace of job creation strengthened from June but remained modest, with service providers hiring more rapidly than manufacturers. Outstanding business volumes declined at the composite level after three months, indicating backlog clearances from services companies. Unfinished work, however, increased for manufacturers.

The SGoS-7 has 14 members, including the commerce secretary, labour secretary, industry secretary, secretary (external affairs), secretary, micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), deputy national security adviser, and the chief economic adviser. The group aims to raise India's share in global trade to 3.8% by 2028-29 and more than 10% by 2047, the people cited above said. India's total exports have grown rapidly in recent years, rising from around \$468 billion in FY24 (2% of global trade) to \$825.26 billion in FY25 (2.5% of global trade), they said. The target is to increase exports to \$1.35 trillion by FY29. After the brainstorming, SGoS-7 will submit its report to the cabinet secretary, which will compile reports from other SGoS and critical appraisals and then the proposed action points will be submitted to the PM for his approval, they said.

HCLTech, Sarvam to build AI data centre in Odisha

NEW DELHI: IT major HCLTech, in partnership with AI firm Sarvam and the Odisha government, will set up its first AI data center in the upcoming Odisha Sovereign AI Park, with a planned capital outlay of ₹14,257 crore.

A Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to this effect was signed by HCLTech, Sarvam, and the Odisha government in the presence of chief minister Mohan Charan Majhi,

HCLTech Chairperson Roshni Nadar Mahotra, HCLTech CEO & MD C Vijayakumar, and Sarvam Co-Founder Pratyush Kumar.

"... Relating to its proposed entry into the full-stack AI market, HCLTech... plans to set up its first AI data center in the upcoming Odisha Sovereign AI Park. The AI data center will be established in partnership with Sarvam and the Government of Odisha."

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NEW DELHI: Vehicles left to authorised dealers for more than six months without being sold could automatically become the dealer's property, while ownership transfers may be blocked if the vehicle has pending challans, unpaid user fees or invalid documents, under draft amendments to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules released by the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) on Friday.

The proposed changes seek to regulate transactions in the organised used-car market, streamline ownership transfers and strengthen compliance requirements. The ministry has invited public comments on the draft rules within 30 days.

Under the proposed Rule 558B, if a registered owner hands over a vehicle to an authorised dealer after filing Form 29C, but the vehicle's registration is not transferred through Form 30 within six months, ownership would automatically

stand transferred to the last authorised dealer in possession of the vehicle. The transfer would be reflected on the VAHAN portal as if it had taken place under Section 50 of the Motor Vehicles Act.

The draft also proposes that ownership of a motor vehicle cannot be transferred if it does not have a valid registration certificate, insurance certificate or pollution under control (PUC) certificate, or if it has pending traffic challans or unpaid user fees.

Similar restrictions have been proposed before a vehicle can be handed over to an authorised dealer or transferred between authorised dealers no more than twice before ownership is transferred to the eventual buyer through Form 30. Every transfer between dealers would have to be electronically reported on the VAHAN portal, with an acknowledgment generated automatically. The registering authority would also electronically inform the registered owner each time the vehicle is delivered to another authorised dealer.

vehicle delivered by its owner to an authorised dealer can be transferred between authorised dealers no more than twice before ownership is transferred to the eventual buyer through Form 30. Every transfer between dealers would have to be electronically reported on the VAHAN portal, with an acknowledgment generated automatically. The registering authority would also electronically inform the registered owner each time the vehicle is delivered to another authorised dealer.

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Positive discussions underway on UCC, environment and other issues



Vandana Shukla released back over bombing on island

SC PULLS UP ED OVER DELAY, GRANTS PRAYAG DIRECTORS BAIL

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: Pulling up the Enforcement Directorate (ED) for "sleeping" over a money laundering case for nearly a decade and faulting the lack of coordination between central investigating agencies, the Supreme Court on Friday granted regular bail to Prayag Group principal directors Basudeb Bagchi and his son Avik Bagchi in a case involving the alleged defrauding of investors of nearly ₹2,862 crore.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said that an accused cannot be made to suffer because central agencies failed to coordinate with each other and did not act with promptitude, questioning why the ED waited until 2024 to register its Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) despite the predicate offence being investigated by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) since 2014.

"Why did you not arrest him in this case when he was already in custody? Were you sleeping? What were you doing for ten years when you claim that money laundering was continuous for the last several years," the bench asked additional solicitor general SV Raju, appearing for the ED.

The court further observed that the Bagchis had remained in CBI custody for a considerable period and the ED's case itself was founded on the CBI investigation.

"He was in the custody of the CBI for a long period. Your case is based on the CBI case after all. Why did you not register the ECIR since 2014?" the bench asked.

When Raju informed the court that the ECIR was registered only in 2024 in Calcutta, the bench responded: "Then that is your problem... These are all central government agencies. If you do not have any coordination, that is your problem. It is for you to have better coordination. For this, you cannot drag the prosecution for ten years."

The bench also questioned the ED on the basis for initiating a fresh ECIR in 2024, observing that no new incident had been cited in the prosecution complaint despite the predicate offence dating back to 2014.

FM calls for taxpayer-friendly regime, reduced litigation

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NEW DELHI: With the 31 July income tax return (ITR) filing deadline approaching, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday asked officials to make the system more taxpayer-friendly by easing compliance for honest taxpayers while taking action against evasion. She said certainty in the tax regime is critical for the economy.

Addressing the 167th Income Tax Day celebrations, FM said the department should give taxpayers with an opportunity to correct bona fide mistakes.

"Our approach should ensure convenience for the honest taxpayer, an opportunity to correct bona fide errors, and firm consequences for deliberate evasion," she said, adding that a taxpayer is "not merely an assessee; a taxpayer is a stakeholder in India's development."

The minister called for a shift



Nirmala Sitharaman, finance minister.

from litigation management to litigation prevention, saying tax certainty is one of the strongest foundations of voluntary compliance and an economic impetus that improves the ease of doing business while strengthening India's competitiveness as a global investment destination.

She urged tax officers to resolve appeals fairly and consistently, so that taxpayers gain confidence in the system instead of returning to litigation. Litigation prevention should rest on three pillars: clarity in taxpayer obligations through timely circulars, consistency in interpretation across jurisdictions, and institutional learning from appellate orders to shape future reforms.

Appeals, returns and refunds. The minister noted that the total pendency of appeals is down by over 34,000 cases to about 5.4 lakh, while around 6,000 departmental appeals have been withdrawn. Following the enhanced monetary thresholds announced in Budget 2024-25, enabling the department to focus on cases involving substantial questions of law.

The tax department has evolved from being primarily a tax collection agency into one focused on fairness, efficiency, ease of doing business and taxpayer service, she said, adding that the implementation of the Income Tax Act, 2025 has simplified the law by integrating provisions, reducing uncertainty and lowering compliance costs.

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★

2		9			7		
9	4			2	1	3	5
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1	5		3				
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	9				2		6

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE - HIGH - LOW

SATURDAY	SUNDAY	MONDAY
Generally cloudy sky with light rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain
30°C 20°C	30°C 20°C	30°C 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is 25th July 2026

10:50 AM, 34°C, 100% Humidity, 10:50 AM, 34°C, 100% Humidity

Sunrise: Saturday 5:48 AM, Sunset: Saturday 6:21 PM, Moonrise: Saturday 10:50 AM, Moonset: Sunday 10:50 AM

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi	34°C 25°C
Mumbai	28°C 26°C
Kolkata	30°C 26°C
Chennai	28°C 26°C
Bengaluru	30°C 20°C

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CWG begins with vibrant colours, Scottish flavour



(L-R) Britain's King Charles, with Queen Camilla, opened the 23rd edition of CWG. Indian contingent enters the Ovo Hydro arena. Artists perform during the opening ceremony in Glasgow. AP/PTI

Consistent Gulveer hopes to push for a strong finish

The 28-year-old runner has been on the mark for India in recent times, aims to make a big splash

Avishhek Roy
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NEW DELHI: Gulveer Singh has gradually raised his standard in long-distance races at the world level, and the CWG in Glasgow provides an opportunity to test his mettle against some of the world's best runners.

In the last two years, Gulveer has reset the national records in the 5,000m and 10,000m in races outside India. Winning gold in both gruelling events at the Asian Championships has added to his aura, and he was also one of the few Indians to receive invitations to the Diamond League.

It was at the World Championships in Tokyo, though, where Gulveer said he learnt his most crucial lesson. He finished 16th in 10,000m and narrowly missed qualifying for the 5,000m final. In the 5,000m heats, Gulveer was running behind Norway's two-time Olympic champion Jakob Ingebrigtsen, who beat him to the final qualifying spot. Gulveer, who clocked 13:42.34, missed the final by a mere 0.19 seconds.

Running international races is completely different, especially medal races where there is so much at stake. Everyone comes with their own strategy and wants to run their own race. Medal races are slow. Everyone is thinking of winning a medal. The finish is important and it is fast. If you run fast early, you will run out of breath. So you have to assess your own capacity and go along with the field," Gulveer told HT. "I don't want to go out there with any particular strategy and will see how the race unfolds. Yes, I would be looking to run close to the lead group and then see how to take it forward," he said.

Long-distance races are as much about endurance and speed as they are about strategy. The field in Glasgow will be high quality, with the presence of runners from Kenya and Uganda, countries known for their domination at the Games. At the Birmingham CWG, Uganda's Jacob Kiplimo won the 5,000m gold medal with a timing of 13:08.08, while Kenyans Nicholas Kimeli and Jacob Krop claimed silver and bronze. In the 10,000m too, Kiplimo took gold (27:09.95), followed by Kenya's Daniel Ekenoyi and Kibiwott Kandie.

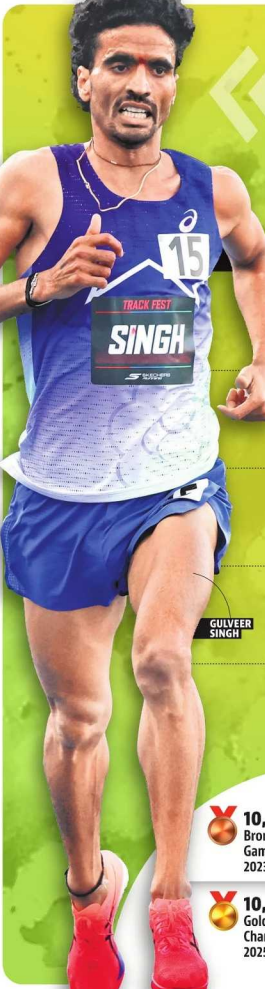
Gulveer's personal best in the 5,000m is 13:03.93, while in the 10,000m it is 27:00.22. But clocking the fastest times is no guarantee of medal success in distance races. It is more about making a steady start, staying with the lead group and having the conviction to break away and push the body in the final stages, when the legs are heavy and the mind begins to waver.

Gulveer has a good finishing kick, but he has been preparing extra hard to make it even more lethal. He has competed in 1,500m races to add speed.

"Be it the World Championships or the Diamond League, I did my best as per my capability. But I realised that it takes a lot out of you to push yourself in such high-stakes races, and therefore I have worked harder on my endurance and speed. I have mixed my races, competing in the 5,000m, 10,000m, half marathon and 15,000m this year. Also, you need to recover well after these gruelling races. So a good diet and proper recovery are important, and I have been focusing on that," says the Army man.

What gives him confidence is his training in Colorado Springs in the US, where he has been training under Scott Simmons for the last couple of seasons.

"I was at the US camp for five months this season and competed in the World Cross Country Championships, half marathons and other races in the US against tough competitors. When I joined the camp and started training with Kenyan and other international athletes in the group, some of whom are Olympians and World Championships medalists, I used to be behind them. I was nowhere close to them in training, but they are surprised to see me running alongside them. They tell me that I have improved and am now running shoulder to shoulder with them. That has given me belief. It gives you so much confidence when you hear something like that," said Gulveer, who is sponsored by ASICS. "I am fortunate that I now have so much support from my sponsors, the AFI and the government. It has helped me compete abroad and raise my standards. There was a time when I had to buy shoes with my own savings. Now I have a sponsor to take care of that. It just allows you to focus on running and winning races."



Looking to ace the distance

The long-distance runner will compete in 5000m and 10000m events in his maiden Commonwealth Games in Glasgow

ACHIEVEMENTS

13:03m93s
National record in 5,000m

12:59.77
National record in 5,000m short track

27:00.22
National record in 10,000m

7:34.49
National record in 3,000m

59:42
Personal best in half-marathon

10,000m
Bronze in Asian Games 2023

5,000m
Gold in Asian Championships 2025

10,000m
Gold in Asian Championships 2025

5,000m
Gold in National Inter State 2026

Nehra looks for CWG springboard to Asian Games

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MUMBAI: Last month, Aryan Nehra knocked off a much-needed timing benchmark. For a couple of years after his first sprang onto the big stage in 2023, Nehra chased that sub-8 minute mark in 800m freestyle with an obsessive mindset. He waded through Olympic-sized pressures, health setbacks and form dips even as the elusive number stayed out of reach.

Now, in the 22-year-old's first CWG, Nehra wants to look beyond timing targets. He is eyeing a bigger picture — the Asian Games — while testing himself in a much more competitive field in Glasgow. "For me, the most important thing is to be ready for Asian Games. The CWG will be a cool opportunity to race world-

class swimmers in a high-level environment before Asian Games," Nehra told HT. "The CWG is about racing and executing well, like a prep run for Asian Games. I'd be more focussed on the times at Asian Games. I'm not focussed on crazy times at the CWG. If it happens, it happens. I'm more worried about execution and how I swim rather than the times."

The Gujarat swimmer is fresh off scripting a significant time that was "massive" for him. At the Nationals in Ahmedabad last month, the home boy clocked 7:59.36 in 800m to become the first Indian to do so. He also set a new national record in 1,500m freestyle (15:44.88), in which he will also compete in Glasgow.

Nehra had been after that sub-8 mark "for a long time," while "also hoping that nobody



Indian swimmer Aryan Nehra. He would get there before me". Having clocked 8:03 in April 2023, it took longer than expected for the youngster to bridge the gap. Part of the reason, he admitted, was getting a bit too consumed by simply the number. "I got into my own head a little," Nehra said. "The good thing is now that I've finally achieved it, I can dis-

take myself from it."

Nehra was touted to do that after a breakthrough 2023, in which the teen notched up a flurry of personal bests across disciplines to earn a spot at the World Championships and Asian Games. Training as a student-athlete at the University of Florida in the company of

the likes of Caleb Dressel and Katie Ledecky, the next two years weren't as productive for the young Indian. "In the lead up to Paris, I stopped enjoying the process. I guess I took it a bit too seriously, and lost that balance. Then, next season, I had some health issues that threw most of my season apart."

Nehra had a coaching change last year, heading to Antibes, France, to train under Fred Vergnoux as part of the World Aquatics Swim Development Programme. He was in a smaller programme compared to Florida, but with a larger personalised connect with the coach. "At this stage of my career, that's exactly what I needed," he said.

Working with Vergnoux, Nehra went from "being in quite unlit shape in October" to "being pretty fast by December". Nehra

has had six straight months of "solid, continuous, consistent and high-quality training". More importantly, he has found the groove he needs to stay in the pool. "I've put a conscious effort in the last couple of months to maintain that balance as I get closer to the major events. That's what allows me to perform at my best."

The Asian Games in September-October is where Nehra believes he can shine. "The CWG, though, comes as a key testing point before that."

"At the National, I was kind of racing with myself. At the CWG, I'll have to deal with a very competitive environment. To be able to race those people on that day, I need to use this opportunity to the fullest. That's exactly the kind of racing experience I need before the Asian Games."

PEATY STARTS QUEST FOR MORE GOLD MEDALS

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GLASGOW: Olympic champions Adam Ramsay-Peaty and Duncan Scott made a fast start in the pool as the 23rd Commonwealth Games kicked into gear on Friday. With the programme nearly hatched, the 10 sports after Glasgow, which also hosted in 2014, stepped in to save the Games after the Australian state of Victoria pulled out, swimming is the highlight of the schedule across the opening weekend. Scott is hoping to land Scotland's first gold on home soil in the 200m individual medley final but was far from happy after only qualifying fifth.

GLASGOW CORNER

TULIKA SUSPENDED FOR WHEREABOUTS FAILURE, WITHDRAWN FROM CWG

Birmingham Commonwealth Games silver medal-winning judoka Tulika Maan has been withdrawn from the ongoing Glasgow edition after being handed a provisional suspension by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for three whereabouts failures in the last 12 months.

Maan had won silver in the +78kg category in the 2022 edition and she was a strong medal prospect in Glasgow as well. She now stares at a two-year ban. "She has committed three whereabouts failures in a 12-month period and NADA has sent notice to her. So, she will be withdrawn from the team," a judo coach said in an official statement. The 27-year-old from Delhi is the second judoka to have been withdrawn from Glasgow CWG after Arun Kumar.



A MEDAL YOU CAN READ BY TOUCH

When medals are draped around the necks of Commonwealth Games podium finishers here, some winners would notice something unusual beneath the medals. The medals are fashioned as a Reuleaux triangle, inspired by the city's coat of arms. The patterns on the surface are drawn from the Finnieston Crane, one of Glasgow's best-known landmarks and a reminder of its shipbuilding past. The textured finish is inspired by tartan.

Powerlifter Ashok ends 4th, Jadumani in last 16

HT Correspondent
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MUMBAI: Para powerlifter Ashok Malik finished fourth in the men's lightweight category, even as India's boxing campaign got off to a winning start at the Commonwealth Games (CWG) in Glasgow on Friday.

Ashok, the 2024 Paris Paralympian from Sonapat, finished just outside the podium with a total of 143.8 points, behind England's Mark Swan (153.9 points), Nigeria's Roland Ezruike (153.9) and Malaysia's Bonnie Bunyau Gustin (153.5). The Indian successfully attempted 195kg and 200kg, but couldn't lift 205kg for his third attempt.

Ashok was struck with polio at age five. He was inspired to start a sport while watching the 2010 Commonwealth Games in New Delhi as a college student.

Soon, he got into powerlifting. Despite the loss of his father in 2020, he did not deter from his sporting aspirations, and won bronze at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games in 2023.

Another Indian, Parmjeet Kumar, finished sixth in the same event with 135.6 points. In the women's lightweight category, Jaspreet Kaur finished sixth with 96.4 points while Suman Devi was seventh with 88.4 points.

Later, Jadumani Singh packed in a good first punch for India's boxing campaign, winning against local hope Aaron Cullen of Scotland 5-0 by unanimous decision in the men's 55kg Round of 32 bout.

Jadumani was quicker and more attacking than his oppo-

RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)

BOXING

Men's 55kg Round of 32
Jadumani Singh Mandhangam beat Aaron Cullen (SCO) 5-0.
Advances to Round of 16

PARA SWIMMING

Men's S13 100m freestyle heats
RVVBK Budgina and Imam Ali qualified for final

SWIMMING

Men's 50m backstroke heats
Srihari Natraj qualified for semi-final

BOWLS

Women's pairs, Group B
India beat South Africa 2-0
Men's singles, Group D
Putal Sonowal beat Cecil Alexander (FLK) via tiebreak

PARA POWERLIFTING

Men's lightweight final
Ashok ended 4th

Men's 50kg final
Parmjeet Kumar was 7th

Women's lightweight final
Jaspreet Kaur ends 8th

Suman Devi ends 8th

ponent in the first round. Even though the crowd favourite stepped up slightly in the second, all the judges gave the Indian the upper hand in the contest.

The Indian set up a clash with Pakistan's Samana Rehman but on Sunday for a place in the quarter-final.

But received a bye in his opening round, and the bout should be a cracking contest between the pugilists from the two rival nations.

Swimming into semis

In the pool, Srihari Natraj did just about enough to progress from the men's 50m backstroke heats and qualify for the semi-finals. The ace Indian swimmer clocked 25.52 seconds to be placed joint 14th overall, and fifth in his heat 4.

Srihari had a creditable Commonwealth Games outing four years ago in Birmingham, where he made the finals of the 50m backstroke (finished 5th) and 100m backstroke (finished 7th) apart from bettering his own national record in the 200m backstroke.

In para swimming, RVVBK

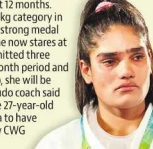
Budgina and Imam Ali finished 3rd (57.10s) and 8th (1:05.32s), respectively. In their men's 100m freestyle S13 heats, All eight swimmers from the single heats qualified for the final.

Putal Sonowal, who made a bright start for India in bowls on the opening day, pulled off another challenging tiebreak victory in his second men's singles Section D match.

Sonowal beat Cecil Alexander of Falkland Islands 7-5, 6-8 (1-0) to remain in good position to advance to the next stage in singles. The Commonwealth Games debutant had upset reigning world outdoor champion Ryan Bester in his first round match on Friday.

The Indian women's pair of Pinki and Rupa Rani Tirkey dished out a much more clinical performance in their second round. Section B match, brushing aside South Africa 2-0 (6-4, 7-5).

They overcame some nervous moments against South Africa in the second set but ensured that, unlike against Malta on the opening day, they did not take matters to a tiebreak.



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Anahat enters Jr World semi-finals

NIAGARA-ON-THE-LAKE: Indian top seed Anahat Singh moved into the women's semi-finals of the World Squash Junior Championships here. World No.20 Anahat defeated Egypt's Habiba Rizk 11-7, 11-5, 6-11, 11-9 in the quarter-finals. The Delhi girl, a bronze medal-winning semi-finalist last year, is the first Indian to reach back-to-back semi-finals in World Juniors. She will face Egyptian Barb Sameh next.

Sainyam wins 10m air pistol silver

HANGZHOU: Sainyam opened India's medal tally at the ISSF World Cup by clinching silver in women's 10m air pistol here on Friday. Sainyam registered 243.4 to secure the podium finish against an elite field. She had qualified for the final with a score of 579.

India get direct quarters entry

NEW DELHI: Defending champions India and Pakistan have been given direct entry into quarter-finals of both the men's and women's cricket competition of the Asian Games. The Indian women's team will open its campaign against Japan while the men's opponents will be decided after the preliminary stage.

Ministry gives NSF status to FMSCI

NEW DELHI: The sports ministry has provisionally granted the status of National Sports Federation (NSF) to the Federation of Motor Sports Clubs of India (FMSCI), a significant upgrade for the body that is coordinating with the government to bring Formula 1 back India.

LeBron to join Philadelphia 76ers

PHILADELPHIA: LeBron James announced on Friday his decision to join the Philadelphia 76ers for his record-extending 24th NBA season with hopes of helping the franchise snap a 43-year title drought. James spent the last eight seasons with the LA Lakers.

Mayank 2.0: After injury layoff, the pacer is smarter, deadlier



India pacer Mayank Yadav in Harare.

Sideline for two years, the fast bowler doesn't waste time to pitch his case with a near-perfect first ball

Somshuvra Laha

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KOLKATA: Mayank Yadav's first ball said everything two lost years couldn't. Bowled at 149 kph, angling in before straightening just enough to surprise Brian Bennett, who could only feather it through to the wicket-keeper. There can never be a perfect delivery but this came pretty close.

For Mayank, the scoreboard will remember the dismissal as a golden duck. His body might remember it as something far more significant. Looseners or the ones sprayed wide, comeback deliveries of fast bowlers are rarely pretty. But this was different. It wasn't merely the first ball of an innings. It was the first ball of a career that had threatened to disappear almost as quickly as it had arrived.

When Mayank burst onto the scene in 2024, India appeared to have discovered the rarest commodity in modern cricket: a fast bowler capable of unsettling batters with raw pace. Then came the injuries. One after another. All on expected lines but rarely this quickly into a career. Instead of learning his trade in international cricket, he found himself learning patience

in rehabilitation centres.

"It was very difficult," Mayank admitted after returning with a Player-of-the-Match performance of 2/18. "The gap of two years was a challenge because age wasn't on my side. I was just 22-23. I felt that I had to suffer so much at a young age."

That sense of injustice is understandable. Fast bowlers accept pain as an occupational hazard, but few expect to spend their formative years watching from the sidelines. While contemporaries accumulated caps and experience, Mayank dabbled with recovery schedules and fitness reports.

Yet his comeback carried none of the desperation that often accompanies prolonged absences. The pace was intact. More importantly, the control appeared sharper.

His opening spell was a study in discipline rather than speed alone. Bennett's dismissal came from intelligent use of the surface as much as express pace, while the remainder of the spell consistently denied Zimbabwe's batters any rhythm.

Mayank revealed that the conversations among India's young pace attack had little to do with who bowled fastest. Instead, they revolved around exploiting conditions.

"We don't talk a lot about pace, but we have a nice bond," he said. "I bowled the first over today, so I shared inputs with Prince and Ashok about the assistance I got and the better options to attack. We were in a

very good situation after the first six overs. The conversations were about how much more we could squeeze them."

That perhaps says as much about Mayank's evolution as the speed gun does. Once the young tearaway who first grabbed attention with eye-catching pace has now appeared to have transformed into someone who understands that fast bowling at the highest level is a collective exercise in pressure, not merely a contest of bragging rights. That sense of maturity is worth its weight in gold.

Patience has kept Mayank afloat. Throughout his rehabilitation, one thought kept him going. "The motivation to play for the country was always there," he said. "So I wanted to make a comeback and perform as I did before."

Against Zimbabwe, he arguably performed better than before. This was a more rounded fast bowler — still rapid enough to trouble international batters, but measured enough to appreciate that wickets are often created by plans rather than pace alone.

There will be sterner examinations than Zimbabwe. Stronger batting line-ups will ask tougher questions of his body and his skill.

After four injuries and two years away, nobody should pretend the road ahead will be straightforward. But every comeback needs a defining image. For Mayank, it may forever remain that first ball in Harare.

Anand to run for dy prez again

BENGALURU: Following a quick turn of events, five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand seems poised to run for FIDE deputy president for a second time.

Late on Thursday, Anand stepped in to take on the duties of interim president of the inter-

national chess federation (FIDE) after its Russian head Arkady Dvorkovich was placed on the latest European Union sanctions list. Dvorkovich was seeking a third term in office, with Kazakh billionaire Timur Turlov as his running mate for deputy president.

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Klopp named new Germany coach

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FRANKFURT: Jurgen Klopp began his tenure as Germany coach with a warning to the media on Friday, saying he would quit the job if his family was not left in peace, as he was unveiled on a four-year contract.

The 59-year-old German, known for his high-intensity football and direct communication style, has been tasked with leading the four times world champions into a new era after another disappointing World Cup campaign.

The former Liverpool and Borussia Dortmund manager replaces Julian Nagelsmann, who stepped down from the role after Germany's penalty shoot-out defeat by Paraguay in the Round of 32, extending the country's run of poor World Cup performances following group-

stage exits in 2018 and 2022. "If you behave badly and don't leave my family in peace then I'll be gone. I'll just turn away," Klopp told reporters. "I'm not doing this job for myself. I'm doing it for you. I'm taking this job even though I've seen how you've treated Julian Nagelsmann and Thomas Tuchel. I love this job but I am always ready to call it quits if need be."

Klopp, who had been working as Red Bull's global head of football after leaving Liverpool in 2024, will be assisted in the role by Peter Krawietz, Pep Lijnders and former German international Sven Bender.

In a typically expressive introductory press conference, he said the national team could connect "as Ger-

many would like hardly anything else" and that he was "looking forward to this special task in German football." German football association (DFB) president Bernd Neundorff said Klopp had been the federation's preferred candidate from the outset. "Our talks with Jurgen only strengthened our belief that he's the right man at the right time," Neundorff added.

Red Bull executive Oliver Mintzlaff said the company had agreed to release Klopp to allow him to take the Germany job. "This wasn't an easy decision but together with my fellow managing directors, Franz Witzlaczek and Alexander Kirchmayr, we decided to support his ambition," Mintzlaff said.

Neundorff said the federation would donate €1 million to Red Bull's Wings for Life foundation instead of paying compensation. He confirmed Leipzig would host three Germany internationals in the coming years.

Germany's latest early exit marked a third successive disappointing World Cup for a team that last lifted the trophy in 2014. Klopp takes the job less than two years after joining Red Bull. He worked as a TV pundit for German broadcasters during the World Cup and was widely viewed as the preferred choice among Germany fans.

However, he drew criticism during the tournament and later apologised after suggesting Nagelsmann's time as national coach could be nearing an end.

One of Germany's most successful club coaches, Klopp won two Bundesliga titles and the German Cup with Borussia Dortmund before taking charge of Liverpool in 2015.

DUTCHMAN VAN BOMMEL NAMED NEW BELGIUM FOOTBALL COACH

Agence France-Presse

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BRUSSELS: Mark van Bommel is the new coach of the Belgian national football team, the Royal Belgian Football Association (RBFA) announced on Friday.

The 48-year-old former Dutch international succeeds Frenchman Rudi Garcia, who stepped down having guided the 'Red Devils' to the World Cup quarter-finals. "Mark van Bommel has signed a contract that will see him lead Belgium's national team through UEFA EURO 2028," read an RBFA statement.

Van Bommel, who was an uncompromising midfielder and key member of the lost Netherlands side that lost to Spain in the 2010 World Cup final, said it was a "great honour" to have been appointed.

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